

THE WOMAN IN MY PHONE

A Novel by A. Rathna

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For everyone who's been the villain of someone else's story and didn't know it yet.

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"The best love stories aren't written. They're remembered."

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★ *Meera / Priya POV*

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PART ONE: THE HUNGER

July 2018

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CHAPTER 1: THE HUNGER

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TikTok Analytics Dashboard — @ari_live99

July 2018

Followers: 20,247 Total Likes: 394,832 Average
Live Viewers: 280-340 Most Active Hours: 9:00 PM –
12:30 AM PST Top Content: Tamil Cinema Voiceovers,
Live Song Games

* * *

There's a number that TikTok doesn't track.

It doesn't measure the silence between the last Live viewer logging off and the moment you set your phone on the nightstand. It doesn't count how many nights you reach across the bed and find nothing but cold sheet. It doesn't calculate the distance between two people sleeping three feet apart who haven't touched in months.

If it did, my analytics would look very different.

* * *

Text Messages — Ari to Priya *June 14, 2018*

Ari: Want to grab dinner tonight? That Thai place you liked. **Priya:** Already ate.

June 21, 2018

Ari: Movie tonight? **Priya:** Tired.

July 2, 2018

Ari: I miss you. *Read 9:47 PM*

* * *

Three words. Read receipt. No reply.

That's my marriage in a screenshot.

We didn't fight. Fighting requires caring enough to raise your voice. We coexisted. Two signatures on a lease. Two names on a mailbox. Two strangers who once loved each other enough to stand in front of a priest and say forever.

Forever turned out to be about three years. The rest was autopilot.

She stopped touching me. I don't mean sex. I mean everything. No hand on my shoulder when she walked by. No feet tangled under the blanket. No casual brush of fingers when passing the salt. My wife had made me invisible, and the worst part was she never announced it. There was no conversation. No "I don't want you anymore." Just a slow withdrawal, like a tide going out

so gradually you don't notice until you're standing on dry sand wondering where the ocean went.

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Google Search History — Ari's Browser *July 2018*

“wife won't touch me” “sexless marriage normal”
“how to reconnect with spouse” “why does my wife avoid intimacy” “am I unattractive” “is my marriage over”

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I tried. God, I tried. I'd reach for her in bed and she'd turn. I'd suggest dinner and she'd say she already ate. I'd kiss her forehead goodnight and she'd stiffen, barely, almost imperceptibly, but enough. Enough for a man who was paying attention.

I was always paying attention. That was my problem.

So I went where people wanted me.

* * *

TikTok Live — @ari_live99 *July 8, 2018, 10:14 PM*
PST Viewers: 312

@ari_live99: Okay okay okay, listen. First three notes only. Ready?

[Plays piano intro]

@tamil_queen_88: VENNILAVE
VENNILAVE!!! **@chennaigirl:** Vennilave!!

@deepa_dreams: OMG VENNILAVE 🥹🥹🥹

@rajesh_usa: Too easy bro give us a hard one

@moviebuff_sri: That song makes me cry every time

@ari_live99: Deepa gets it first! Okay next one. This is harder. Listen carefully...

[Plays flute melody]

@tamil_queen_88: Roja?? **@rajesh_usa:**
Kadhal Rojave **@meera_m:** Pudhu Vellai Mazhai

@ari_live99: Wait wait wait — who said Pudhu Vellai Mazhai? That's... that's correct. From the B-side. Nobody gets that one.

* * *

I know how it sounds. A grown man seeking validation on a fifteen-second video app. But you have to understand: when no one in your real life looks at you, the algorithm becomes a kind of God. It sees you. It rewards you. It says: *more of this, please. We want more of you.*

I did Tamil movie voiceovers. Took classic scenes: Kamal's monologue in Indian where he tells his son he has to kill him. Rajini's farewell in Thalapathi where he walks into the rain and never looks back. The breakup in Alaipayuthey where Madhavan says "I didn't know love could be this tiring" and every married person in the audience inhales. I gave them my face. Not imitation. Interpretation. I'd find the emotion underneath the dialogue and pull it to the surface.

People responded. First a hundred followers. Then a thousand. Then twenty thousand. The comments flooded in. *"Brother, your voice made me cry."* *"This is exactly how that scene should feel."* *"Do you do Live sessions?"*

Live sessions. That's where it really started.

* * *

TikTok Live — @ari_live99 July 15, 2018, 11:42 PM PST Viewers: 287

@ari_live99: You know what, forget the games for a minute. Can I just talk?

@chennaigirl: Yes bro go ahead

@deepa_dreams: We're listening ❤️

@ari_live99: Sometimes I think... we spend so much time trying to be seen by the people closest to us.

And they're the ones who look right through us. And then strangers — people in a chat, people who've never met you — they see you clearer than anyone.

@lonely_in_london: Bro that hit different 🥺

@tamil_queen_88: Who hurt you ❤️

@meera_m: That's because strangers have no reason to look away.

* * *

I read that comment three times.

“Strangers have no reason to look away.”

Most comments in a Live scroll by like credits at the end of a movie. You catch fragments. A name here, an emoji there. But some comments stop the scroll. Some comments reach through the screen and touch something you didn't know was exposed.

I didn't respond to it on air. I just kept talking. But I saw the username. Filed it somewhere in the back of my mind. Like a stone pocketed from a beach. Its weight just felt right.

* * *

TikTok Live Chat Frequency — @meera_m July 2018

July 8: Present (3 comments) July 9: Present (7 comments) July 10: Absent July 11: Present (12 comments) July 12: Present (9 comments) July 13: Present (15 comments) July 14: Present (11 comments) July 15: Present (8 comments)

Song Game Wins: 14 Average Response Time: 2.3 seconds Accuracy Rate: 91%

* * *

She kept winning. Every single night. Like she lived inside the same music I did.

The regulars started noticing. “She’s too fast!” “Is she cheating?” “Bro she knows every song before you finish playing the first note.”

She wasn’t cheating. She was just... tuned to the same frequency. The same movies. The same melodies. The same heartbreak set to music only South Indians understand. The particular madness of Tamil cinema, where a man will stand in the rain for forty-five minutes to prove a point, where mothers have a sixth sense that activates exclusively when their children are in danger or lying about marriage, where every love story requires at least one train station goodbye and a minimum of three costume changes.

* * *

Home — 12:47 AM

Live ended.

Phone on nightstand.

Bathroom. Water. Back to bed. Priya facing the wall. The shape of her back like a closed door.

I lay there in the dark, listening to her breathe, and thought about a username I didn't know. A girl in a chat who heard what I heard.

Three hundred people in a room every night, hanging on my words.

One woman in this bed who wouldn't look at me.

* * *

TikTok Notification *July 16, 2018, 1:03 AM PST*

@ari_live99 sent a Direct Message to @meera_m

“Hey. You keep winning my song games. Either you're a bot or you grew up in the same decade of Tamil cinema I did. Which one? 😊”

* * *

I should have known right then.

When someone hears what you hear, really hears it,
how the melody curls before the drop, how the lyrics
break at exactly the right word, that's not a stranger.
That's a mirror.

* * *

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CHAPTER 2: THE GIRL IN THE CHAT

* * *

TikTok Direct Messages *July 16, 2018*

@ari_live99: Hey. You keep winning my song games. Either you're a bot or you grew up in the same decade of Tamil cinema I did. Which one? 😊

@meera_m: 😂 Definitely not a bot. My mother would play these songs while cooking. I knew every A.R. Rahman melody before I knew my multiplication tables.

@ari_live99: Rahman before math. That's the correct upbringing.

@meera_m: My father would disagree. He wanted an engineer. He got a girl who cries at Mani Ratnam films and married the first man who didn't bore her. Two mistakes, apparently.

@ari_live99: That's not a failure. That's a feature.

@meera_m: That's what I tell myself at 2 AM when the feature is crying in the kitchen 😂

* * *

She was funny. That was the first thing. Not performatively funny, not the humor that performs. Just naturally, effortlessly witty, comfortable with who she was.

The second thing was her speed. Not just in the song games. In conversation. I'd send a message and the reply would come in thirty seconds. Her mind just moved that fast. Like the thoughts were already formed and just needed permission to leave.

We talked for three hours that first night. In DMs. Texts stacking up like bricks in a wall we were building between us without knowing it.

* * *

TikTok Direct Messages *July 16, 2018 — continued*

@ari_live99: What do you do?

@meera_m: Survive mostly 😊 I'm married. Two words that used to mean something. Now it's just a WhatsApp status and a man who snores like he's angry at oxygen.

@ari_live99: I know exactly what you mean.

@meera_m: You're married too?

@ari_live99: On paper.

@meera_m: Same paper, different prison. At least yours is air-conditioned.

* * *

Same paper, different prison.

Six words. And I felt less alone than I had in three years.

I didn't ask for details that night. She didn't offer them. We just circled the wound without touching it, the way you walk around a hole in the floor, both knowing it's there, both pretending you're just admiring the room.

* * *

TikTok Live — @ari_live99 July 17, 2018, 9:58 PM
PST Viewers: 304

@ari_live99: Alright, tonight's game is different. I'm going to play a song, but I'm only going to play the LAST five seconds. The outro. The part nobody remembers. Let's see who really knows their music.

@rajesh_usa: Bro that's impossible

@tamil_queen_88: Bring it 💪 **@deepa_dreams:**
I'm scared lol

[Plays fading violin outro]

@meera_m: Uyire Uyire. Bombay.

@ari_live99: ...how.

@meera_m: The violin does this thing at the end where it climbs and then just... stops. Like it can't finish the sentence. That's the only song that does that.

@tamil_queen_88: Ok she's not human

@rajesh_usa: 🤔🤔🤔 she's a machine

@ari_live99: "It can't finish the sentence." That's... that might be the best thing anyone's said in this chat.

* * *

I meant it. I wasn't flirting. Or maybe I was and didn't know it yet. But how she described music, not by title or singer or film, but by the FEELING of it, was something I'd never encountered in another person.

Priya didn't listen to music. Not really. She'd have it on in the background like people who leave the TV on, for noise, not for meaning. If I played a song and said "listen to this part," she'd nod and go back to her phone.

Meera heard the violin climbing before it stopped. She heard the sentence that couldn't finish. She heard me.

* * *

Video Call Log *July 18, 2018*

Caller: @ari_live99 Receiver: @meera_m Start:
10:47 PM PST / 11:17 AM IST End: 3:12 AM PST / 3:42
PM IST Duration: 4 hours, 25 minutes

* * *

Four hours and twenty-five minutes.

I don't remember deciding to call her. I don't remember the transition from DMs to "should we just talk?" It happened gradually, then all at once.

The first thing I noticed was her face. Not her beauty, though she was beautiful. Dark hair framing dark eyes, a smile that started slow and spread like ink in water. But what I noticed first was how she looked at the camera. Directly. Not at herself in the corner of the screen, not at something off to the side. At ME. Like the phone was a window and she was looking through it.

I hadn't been looked at like that in years.

"Hi," she said.

"Hi," I said.

Then we talked for four hours about everything and nothing. Her childhood in India: the songs her mother played while grinding chutney at 6 AM, the father who wanted an engineer and got a girl who could name

every Mani Ratnam film in chronological order, the rain in her city that turned the streets into rivers and the auto-rickshaw rides into boat trips. My life in America: the tech salary that looked good on paper, the wife who'd rather face drywall than face me, the TikTok Lives that kept me breathing.

We argued about whether Kamal Haasan or Rajinikanth was the better actor (there is no correct answer to this question; there is only the answer that determines whether you can be friends with a person). We debated the greatest A.R. Rahman album (she said Roja, I said Bombay, we agreed to disagree, which in Tamil culture means we'd revisit this fight weekly until one of us died). We talked about marriage like it was a crime scene. We laughed at things that weren't funny and got quiet at things that were too true.

At 2 AM my time, she said: "I should go."

At 2 AM my time, I said: "Five more minutes."

At 3 AM my time, we were still talking.

* * *

TikTok Direct Messages *July 19, 2018, 3:14 AM PST*

@ari_live99: I can't remember the last time I talked to someone for four hours.

@meera_m: I can't remember the last time someone wanted to.

* * *

That line landed in my chest like a stone in still water.

I can't remember the last time someone wanted to.

I could hear it now, not just in her words but in the spaces between them. How she leaned into every question I asked, like no one had asked her anything real in years. She laughed too hard at small jokes, like laughter had been rationed and she was suddenly allowed to spend.

Her husband . She hadn't told me much. Just that the marriage was "complicated." Just that she stayed because leaving was harder than staying. Just that she sometimes forgot what it felt like to be wanted.

I knew that forgetting. I lived in that forgetting.

* * *

TikTok Live — @ari_live99 July 22, 2018, 10:30 PM PST Viewers: 331

@ari_live99: Tonight I'm going to play a full song. No game. I just want you to listen. This one means something to me.

[Plays “Kannathil Muthamittal” — full]

@deepa_dreams: 🥹🥹🥹

@tamil_queen_88: Why are you doing this to us on a Sunday **@lonely_in_london:** Brother I’m crying in my flat rn **@meera_m:** The mother’s love. The child she lost. The searching. You played this for a reason.

* * *

She saw through the song to the man playing it. Every time. Without fail.

The chat saw emotion. She saw intention. The chat heard music. She heard ME.

* * *

Video Call Log — Summary July 18 – July 26, 2018

July 18: 4 hrs 25 min July 19: 3 hrs 12 min July 20: 5 hrs 03 min July 21: 2 hrs 47 min (she had to leave early) July 22: 4 hrs 58 min July 23: 3 hrs 34 min July 24: 6 hrs 11 min July 25: 4 hrs 02 min July 26: 5 hrs 44 min

Total: 39 hours, 56 minutes in 9 days

* * *

Forty hours. In nine days. Two people on opposite sides of the planet, building something in the only space they could share: the space between two screens.

Every night, after Priya went to bed, I'd take my phone to the living room, plug in my earbuds, and call her. India was thirteen and a half hours ahead, which meant her afternoon was my midnight. She'd be sitting by a window with filter coffee and sunlight, the ceiling fan making its lazy circles, maybe a crow arguing with another crow on the balcony because Indian crows have opinions about everything. I'd be in the dark on my couch with American coffee and silence.

We existed in a time zone that didn't belong to any country. It was ours. The hours between her daylight and my darkness. The overlap where both of us were awake and the rest of our lives were asleep.

I started sleeping less. I was tired. But sleep meant hanging up, and hanging up meant going back to the real world, and the real world was a bed where no one touched me and a marriage where no one spoke.

She was becoming my real world. The calls were becoming more real than the house I lived in.

* * *

TikTok Direct Messages *July 26, 2018, 2:47 AM PST*

@meera_m: Can I tell you something?

@ari_live99: Anything.

@meera_m: I haven't felt this alive in years. And that terrifies me.

@ari_live99: Me too.

@meera_m: What are we doing?

@ari_live99: I don't know. But I don't want to stop.

@meera_m: Neither do I. And that's the terrifying part.

* * *

Day ten was the day everything changed. But that's the next chapter.

By July 26th, I was already gone. Not physically. Physically I was exactly where I'd always been. Same house. Same counter. Same keys. Same wife facing the wall.

But the part of me that mattered, the part that hungered and listened and played songs for strangers and read their pain in a scrolling chat, that part had already crossed an ocean.

It was sitting by a window in India, drinking chai in the afternoon sun, looking at a woman with dark eyes who heard violins like I did.

It was never coming back.

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CHAPTER 3: THE OPENING

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TikTok Direct Messages *July 26, 2018, 11:14 PM PST*

@ari_live99: That picture you sent yesterday.
The one by the window.

@meera_m: What about it?

@ari_live99: Your hair. The way it falls over your
shoulder. I keep going back to it.

@meera_m: 😊 It's just hair.

@ari_live99: It's not just hair. Nothing about you
is "just" anything.

@meera_m: You can't say things like that.

@ari_live99: Why not?

@meera_m: Because I'll believe you.

* * *

It had been building for days.

Not sudden. Not cinematic. No single moment of
eye contact across a crowded room. This was slower.
More like a fever. A degree at a time until you don't

realize you're burning until someone touches your forehead and says *you're hot*.

She'd been sending me photos. Not provocative ones. Just her. Morning chai by the window. A new salwar she'd bought. Her hair braided for a friend's wedding. Normal pictures. What you send to someone you trust.

But I wasn't looking at them normally. I was studying them. The curve of her neck. How her dupatta fell across her collarbone. The line of her figure beneath fabric, because I was paying attention with an intensity that turns cotton into silk.

I was starving, remember. And she was standing right there, across an ocean, in my phone, beautiful and warm and sending me photos like it was nothing.

It wasn't nothing.

* * *

TikTok Direct Messages *July 26, 2018, 11:38 PM PST*

@ari_live99: What are you wearing right now?

* * *

Four words that changed everything.

I'd typed and deleted it three times before sending. Because I knew what that question meant. It wasn't curiosity. It wasn't casual. It was a door, and I was choosing to open it.

* * *

@meera_m: Shorts. A t-shirt. Nothing fancy 🤔

@ari_live99: Send me a picture.

@meera_m: Of what? Me in shorts? 😂

@ari_live99: Your legs.

* * *

Silence. The three dots appeared. Disappeared. Appeared again. Disappeared.

Thirty seconds that felt like thirty minutes.

Then: a photo.

Her legs, stretched out on a bed. Bare. Tan skin against white sheets. The shorts riding up just enough. A woman showing a man her legs because he asked, and the asking itself was more intimate than anything that had happened to either of them in years.

* * *

@ari_live99: God.

@meera_m: Stop 😂

@ari_live99: I'm serious. Do you know how beautiful you are?

@meera_m: Nobody's said that to me in a very long time.

@ari_live99: That's a crime.

* * *

I stared at that photo like a painting in a museum. With lust, yes. Also with awe — the awe you feel when something beautiful exists and you can't believe you're allowed to look at it.

Her legs. Just her legs. And I was gone.

* * *

Video Call Log *July 26, 2018*

Caller: @ari_live99 Receiver: @meera_m Start: 11:52 PM PST / 12:22 PM IST Duration: [not logged, we forgot to hang up]

* * *

When the video connected, she was smiling. Nervous. That specific kind of nervous where you know

something is about to happen and you want it but you're terrified of wanting it.

"Hi," she said. Same word as the first call. But everything underneath it had shifted.

"Those legs," I said. "Even better on video."

She laughed. Pulled her knees up to her chest. Half-hiding. Half-showing.

I told her. All of it. How I'd been looking at her pictures differently for days. How her hair falling over her shoulder in that window photo had kept me up at night. How I wanted to touch her and the eight thousand miles between us felt like a physical weight on my chest.

I could see it happening in real time. Her breathing changed. Shallow. Quick. Her lips parting slightly. Her eyes getting darker, or maybe it was the light, but I don't think it was the light.

She was becoming aroused. Visibly. On camera. And I could see it.

"We shouldn't," she whispered.

"I know," I said.

Neither of us hung up.

* * *

I told her what I wanted to do to her. I told her what she'd told me she'd never been told. Forty hours of conversation across nine days and an ocean had given me a vocabulary for her that her husband had never bothered to learn.

I told her I'd start with her neck. That spot behind her ear where her hair gathers. I'd kiss it slowly while my hands found her waist. I'd hold her. Not grab. Hold. The way no one had held her in years.

Her breathing got heavier. Her hand moved to her chest, unconsciously, instinctively, pressing against her own heartbeat.

"Don't stop talking," she whispered.

So I didn't.

I told her about her legs. The ones in the photo. How I'd kiss down the inside of her thigh. How I'd listen to her body, every sound, every shift, every breath, how I listened to music. For the feeling underneath the notes.

She made a sound. Not a word. Just a sound. Small. Like something opening.

"Are you okay?" I asked.

She nodded. Eyes closed. Lips pressed together. Both hands gripping the fabric of her shorts.

"Let go," I said.

And she did.

* * *

Her whole body arched. Her mouth opened. The sound she made was more honest than anything I'd ever heard. Like she'd been holding it for years and it finally broke free.

She came.

Then she cried.

Not from sadness. From shock. From the realization that her body could do that. That pleasure could exist outside of something being done TO her.

* * *

@meera_m (*after, in DMs, because she couldn't say it out loud*): "That has never happened to me before."

* * *

Never. In her entire life. Not with her husband. Not alone. Never.

I read that message and felt like a god. I should have felt like a witness.

* * *

I wanted her to see me too. All of me. So I pulled off my shirt. Then the rest. I let her watch. Naked. Stroking myself. For her. “This is what you do to me. This is how much I want you. Look.”

She looked. Her eyes wide. Her mouth slightly open. Watching that wasn’t passive. Consuming. She was drinking me in like I’d been drinking in her photos for days.

She came again. Watching me. I want to tell you it was about connection. It was also about power. The power of being the man who could do what her husband couldn’t. I didn’t name that then. I’m naming it now.

Then, slowly, nervously, laughing at herself, she undressed too.

“I’ve never done this,” she said.

“I know,” I said. And then I didn’t say anything else, because what else was there.

She touched herself. Tentatively at first, like she was asking permission from her own body. I guided her. Not with commands. With presence. “That’s beautiful. Keep going. Don’t be ashamed of any of it.”

She came again. This time with her own hands. This time with her own body. This time choosing it.

I watched her discover herself through a phone screen in the middle of the night, eight thousand miles

away, and I thought: *this is more intimate than anything I've ever been part of. And I haven't touched her once.*

* * *

Video Call — disconnected *July 27, 2018, 3:47 AM PST*

* * *

We didn't talk about it the next day. Not directly. We didn't need to. The call that evening started where the last one ended, in a space that had no name yet — somewhere between friendship and love.

But I'll tell you what changed: her voice. The next time she called, there was something underneath it that hadn't been there before. Confidence. Not loud confidence, the quiet kind. What comes from discovering that you're allowed to feel good and the world doesn't end.

I told myself I'd given her that. Years later, she'd tell me she gave it to herself — that I was the excuse her body needed, not the cause. She was probably right. But in July 2018, I needed to be the hero of

someone's story, because I damn sure wasn't the hero of my own.

Either way, we both knew: we were never going back to just talking about Tamil songs and bad marriages.

We'd crossed the ocean in a different way now.

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CHAPTER 4: THE LIVE

★ *Meera's POV*

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Phone Screen — TikTok Live @ari_live99 is LIVE

Viewers: 308

* * *

The house was finally quiet.

Meera stood in the hallway for ten seconds, counting breaths — a trick her mother taught her. Ten seconds of standing still, listening to the fan creak overhead and the television murmur from the living room where Vikram was watching cricket. Ten seconds between being a wife and being whatever she became when she opened TikTok.

She padded to the bedroom. Closed the door. Not all the way. Never all the way. Vikram noticed closed doors. Closed doors meant questions. Questions meant proximity. Proximity meant his hands. So she left it cracked. Just enough to hear the cricket commentary. Just enough to know he was still on the couch.

She sat on the bed, back against the headboard, legs crossed, phone propped against a pillow. Opened TikTok. His face filled the screen.

* * *

She'd found him by accident.

Three weeks ago, scrolling through Lives at 11 PM because she couldn't sleep. She was looking for nothing. Tamil comedy clips. Cooking videos. Anything to fill the gap between Vikram falling asleep and her body finally unclenching enough to follow.

Then a voice. A man playing a piano melody she recognized from the first three notes. Kaadhal Rojave. She hadn't heard that song since her mother's kitchen, age twelve, rain on the windows, the smell of rasam on the stove.

She clicked.

He was good-looking. That registered second. First was the voice. Warm and unhurried, like he had nowhere to be. Like this, right here, this silly song game with strangers, was all that mattered in the world. She'd forgotten what it felt like to be in a room where someone wasn't rushing to finish.

Vikram rushed everything. Dinner. Conversations. Sex. Everything was a task to complete, a box to check,

a thing to get through so he could get to the next thing.
Even his cruelty was efficient. Quick. Businesslike.
Done.

This man on the screen was the opposite of done.
He was lingering.

She typed “Pudhu Vellai Mazhai” before she knew
she was typing.

* * *

TikTok Notifications — Meera’s Phone *July 8 –
July 15, 2018*

@ari_live99 went LIVE — 9 notifications
@ari_live99 liked your comment — 4 notifications
@ari_live99 is LIVE — watch now! — 7 notifications
*Screen Time: TikTok — 4 hrs 12 min daily average
(up from 22 min)*

* * *

She told herself it was about the music.

That was the lie she could live with. She wasn’t
watching a man every night. She was listening to Tamil
cinema songs with a community of people who loved
what she loved. There were hundreds of them in the

chat. She was just one viewer. One username among three hundred. Anonymous. Safe.

Except she wasn't anonymous anymore. He'd started noticing her. Reading her comments aloud. "Meera_m says Pudhu Vellai Mazhai. She's right again, what else is new." The chat would erupt. @tamil_queen_88 would type "SHE'S CHEATING" with seventeen laughing emojis. @rajesh_usa would demand a recount.

And Meera would sit on her bed in a cracked-door bedroom in a city in India, grinning like an idiot at her phone, while her husband watched cricket twelve feet away.

Grinning. She'd forgotten what that felt like too.

* * *

The song games were foreplay. She understood that now, weeks later, looking back. Not sexual foreplay. Emotional foreplay. Each correct answer was a small collision. Each time he said her username aloud, something in her chest sparked. Each night she showed up and he noticed, a thread formed. Thin. Invisible. Stronger than it had any right to be.

She started preparing. That was the part she'd never admit to anyone. Before his Lives, she'd scroll

through Tamil song databases, refreshing her memory on B-sides and deep cuts. Not to cheat. To impress him. To be the girl who knew every song. To be seen as special by a man who made three hundred people feel special every night.

She'd never tell anyone she did this. But invisible was worse.

* * *

Google Search History — Meera's Phone *July 2018*

“ari_live99 real name” “Tamil TikTok voiceover guy Seattle” “is it wrong to have feelings for someone online” “emotional affair definition”

Searches cleared at 11:47 PM

* * *

She always cleared the history. Vikram checked her phone sometimes. Not often. Not systematically. Just randomly. Same as everything with him. A sudden grab. “Who are you texting?” Usually nobody. Usually the search history was recipes and home remedies and “how to remove turmeric stain from white sari.” Boring. Safe. The search history of a good wife.

The other searches, the dangerous ones, she cleared within minutes. A reflex. The digital equivalent of washing someone else's cologne off your skin before your husband gets home.

Not that there was cologne. Not that there was anything. Just a man on a screen playing Tamil songs and saying her username like it mattered.

But she cleared the history anyway. Because wanting something, even something that only existed in a chat window, felt like a betrayal in a house where even her thoughts didn't feel private.

* * *

Then the DM came.

“Hey. You keep winning my song games. Either you're a bot or you grew up in the same decade of Tamil cinema I did. Which one? 😊”

She read it four times. Closed the app. Opened it. Read it again. Put the phone face-down on the bed. Picked it up. Read it one more time.

Her hands were shaking. Not from fear. From want. The specific want of a woman who hasn't been spoken to like a person in so long.

She typed back: “😂 Definitely not a bot. My mother would play these songs while cooking.”

Send.

And then she stared at the ceiling and whispered to nobody: “What are you doing, Meera?”

No answer. Just the fan. The cricket commentary bleeding through the cracked door.

She picked up the phone and kept typing.

* * *

Three hours later, he knew about her father. The engineer dream. The Mani Ratnam tears. She knew about his dead marriage, the wife who faced the wall, the couch that had become his country.

“Same paper, different prison,” she’d typed. And meant it so deeply her teeth hurt.

They hadn’t said anything inappropriate. No flirting. No innuendo. Just two people talking the way people talk when they’ve been quiet for too long and suddenly find someone who speaks their language. Not Tamil. Deeper than Tamil. The language of people who could name what was wrong but couldn’t change it.

She put the phone down at 2:30 AM. Vikram’s snoring was a low, steady rumble from across the bed. The house was dark.

Meera lay on her side, facing away from her husband, and realized she was smiling. In bed. In

THIS bed. The bed where he did what he did. The bed she'd learned to leave her body in, floating up to the ceiling while he finished.

She was smiling in that bed. Because of a man who'd asked if she was a bot.

* * *

The calls started two days later. His voice without the Live delay, without the chat scrolling, without three hundred people between them. Just his voice in her ear while Vikram watched his shows and the ceiling fan made its lazy circles.

They talked about everything. The conversations were so easy it scared her. With Vikram, every exchange was a negotiation. A minefield. Words chosen for safety, not truth. "How was your day?" meant "Don't say anything that will set him off." "I'm fine" meant "Please don't ask again."

With Ari, she said things she didn't know she thought until they left her mouth.

"I can't remember the last time someone wanted to hear me talk," she told him one night.

"That's criminal," he said.

"That's marriage," she said.

They both laughed. The bitter kind. The kind where the joke is your life.

* * *

WhatsApp — Voice Note to herself *July 25, 2018, 1:14 AM IST Duration: 0:22 Saved to “Locked” folder*

“I think I’m falling for a man I’ve never touched. A man who lives in a phone. A man who makes me laugh and nobody has made me laugh in three years. I don’t know what to do with this. I don’t know what to do with any of this.”

[Pause]

“I think that’s the problem. I DO know what to do. That’s what scares me.”

* * *

She knew what was coming. She could feel it building the way you feel weather changing. A pressure in the air. A charge between them that got heavier with every call, every laugh, every time he said something that made her close her eyes and press the phone harder against her ear.

She wasn’t naive. She was a married woman in India. She knew exactly what an emotional affair

looked like, what it led to, what it cost. She'd watched enough relatives' marriages implode from exactly this. The whispered phone calls. The sudden brightness in someone's eyes that had nothing to do with the person they came home to.

She was becoming that person. The person she'd judged at family gatherings. The one the aunties clicked their tongues at. "She was talking to some man. On the PHONE. Can you imagine?"

Yes. She could imagine. She was doing it every night. And it was the only thing keeping her alive.

* * *

Night fifteen. The call was different. She could feel it in his voice before he said anything. A lower register. A slowness.

"That picture you sent yesterday," he said. "The one by the window."

Her stomach dropped. Not from fear. From recognition. She knew that tone. She knew where this was going. And she could have stopped it. Could have laughed it off. Could have said "it's just hair" and steered the conversation back to safe water.

Instead, she said: "What about it?"

And leaned back against the headboard. And closed her eyes. And let it happen.

* * *

Later, after he'd talked her through an orgasm she didn't know her body was capable of having, after she'd bitten the pillow to keep quiet because Vikram was twenty feet away, after the shaking stopped and the tears came and she didn't know why she was crying except that something fundamental had just shifted inside her body.

Later, she typed the truest message she'd ever sent:
"That has never happened to me before."

She meant it. Four years married. A body that had been used hundreds of times. And it had never felt like that.

Because nobody had ever tried to give her anything. They only took. Her husband took. Her mother-in-law took. The aunties took. Until she'd accepted that being a woman meant being a thing people took from.

And then a man in a phone had given her something back. Without asking for anything. Without grabbing or pushing or switching off like a light after he finished.

She locked the phone. Set it face-down. Walked to the bathroom. Washed her face. Looked at herself in the mirror. The fluorescent light was unforgiving. Tired eyes. Lines she hadn't noticed before. Hair pulled back in a messy knot.

But she was smiling again.

She turned off the light.

* * *

* * *

* * *

PART TWO: THE MIRROR

August 2018 – March 2019

* * *

CHAPTER 5: THE MIRROR

* * *

WhatsApp Message *August 3, 2018, 2:16 AM PST*

Meera: He did it again tonight.

* * *

Five words. No context needed. I knew what “it” meant by now.

Her husband had forced himself on her. Again. In the same bed where she slept. In the same house where their marriage certificate hung on the wall like a permit for violence.

I was lying on my couch in Seattle, Washington, earbuds in, the blue light of my phone the only thing illuminating the room. Priya was asleep down the hall. Or awake and not caring. It didn’t matter. She existed in a different dimension: one where my phone didn’t ring at 2 AM and my heart didn’t stop every time it did.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *August 3, 2018*

Ari: Are you okay?

Meera: No.

Ari: Tell me.

Meera: I don't want to talk about it. I just wanted to hear your voice.

Ari: I'm here. I'm not going anywhere.

Meera: I know. That's the only thing I know right now.

* * *

Voice Note — Meera to Ari *August 3, 2018, 2:24*

AM PST Duration: 0:47

[Sound of breathing. Uneven. The kind that comes after crying for a long time. A sniffle. Then, quietly:]

"I hate this bed. I hate this room. I hate that he can just... take. Whenever he wants. Like I'm not even a person. Like I'm furniture."

[Pause. Longer breath.]

"The only time I feel like a person is when I'm talking to you."

[End of voice note.]

* * *

I played that voice note seventeen times.

She wasn't just a girl in a chat anymore. She was a woman being raped in her own home, and I was the only person in the world who knew.

* * *

Her cage looked like this.

She married young. They'd been in love once, or what passed for love in a culture where marriage is the finish line and everything after is supposed to figure itself out. He was good-looking. Good family. A match that made mothers proud and aunties nod approvingly at weddings.

The first year was fine. Not magic. Fine. What people mistake for happiness because they've never seen the real thing.

Then it changed. Slowly. Abuse changes that way: so gradually that by the time you realize you're trapped, the door has been locked for years.

He wanted sex. She didn't always want sex. But "didn't always want" became irrelevant. In his mind, marriage was consent: a permanent, irrevocable yes she'd signed on the dotted line the day she said "I do."

In India, marital rape wasn't even a crime. Legally, her body belonged to him the moment they circled the

fire.

So he took. And she endured. Night after night. Week after week. Year after year. Until her body learned to leave the room before he entered it, not physically, but somewhere deep inside, a door would close, and she'd go somewhere else in her mind until it was over.

* * *

Google Search History — Meera's Phone *(She told me about these searches months later, laughing bitterly)*

“is it rape if you're married” “husband forcing sex India law” “how to say no to husband” “is it normal to cry after sex with husband” “why do I feel nothing during sex”

* * *

My cage was different.

Different bars. Same prison.

Priya didn't force anything. Priya didn't take anything. She just... withdrew. Completely. Totally. Like a tide that went out and never came back.

No sex. No touching. No kissing. No hand-holding. No “how was your day?” with actual curiosity behind it. No laughter. No fights. Nothing. The complete absence of intimacy in every form: physical, emotional, spiritual.

Her cage was violence. Mine was vacuum.

She was being drowned. I was being starved.

Somehow, across eight thousand miles and thirteen and a half time zones, we found each other. The woman who needed someone to stop taking, and the man who needed someone to start giving.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App August 2018

“I sleep three feet from a woman who doesn't know I exist. I have 20,000 followers who think they know me. And the only person who actually sees me is on the other side of the planet, married to a man who hurts her, and I can't do a goddamn thing about it.”

* * *

Our days had a rhythm now.

Her afternoon was my midnight. That was our window. She'd take her phone to the small balcony of

her apartment and sit in the plastic chair by the railing, and the light would hit her face the way Indian afternoon light does: golden, forgiving, warm.

I'd be on the couch. Earbuds in. Lights off. Priya asleep or pretending to sleep or genuinely not caring either way.

We'd talk. For hours. Every single day.

* * *

Video Call Log — Summary *August 2018*

Total calls: 29 Total duration: 137 hours, 42 minutes
Average call length: 4 hours, 44 minutes
Longest call: 8 hours, 11 minutes (August 17) Shortest call: 1 hour, 03 minutes (August 22 , her husband came home early)

* * *

One hundred and thirty-seven hours in one month. That's almost six full days of talking. Of looking at each other through screens. Of building a life in the space between two phones.

We'd start with the day. Hers first: what she cooked, whether her mother-in-law was being cruel or just indifferent that day, what small rebellion she'd

managed that afternoon. Then mine: work, the commute, what I ate for dinner alone because Priya was in the bedroom with the door closed.

Then the conversation would deepen. Philosophy. God. Karma. Whether we'd done something terrible in a past life to deserve marriages like ours, or whether we'd done something beautiful to deserve finding each other.

Then it would get quiet. The good quiet. The kind where two people are just... together. Breathing. Existing in the same space even though the space was imaginary.

Most nights, it would turn. A look. A word. The shift in her breathing that I'd learned to read like sheet music. We'd make love through the screen, slowly, deliberately, the way you make love when you know you can't touch and every word has to do the work of a thousand hands.

* * *

WhatsApp Message *August 14, 2018, 3:31 AM PST*

Meera: Sometimes I think you're the only real thing in my life. Everything else is performance. The wife. The daughter-in-law. All roles. You're the only place I'm just... me.

Ari: You're the only place I'm me too.

Meera: Isn't that terrifying?

Ari: Yes.

Meera: That we only exist in each other's phones?

Ari: We exist wherever we are right now. This is real.

Meera: Is it?

Ari: You came last night from my voice alone. That was real. Your tears after were real. The way you said my name was real. Don't let the distance make you doubt what we have just because we can't hold it in our hands.

Meera: 🥺

Ari: What?

Meera: Nothing. I just wish you were here. Physically. Just once. Just to know what your arms feel like.

* * *

She wished I was there. I wished she was here. And eight thousand miles of ocean and air and border and culture and marriage and fear and guilt and God sat between us like a wall we couldn't climb.

So we did what we could. We loved each other through screens. We healed each other with voices. We

came together across thirteen time zones and pretended, no, believed, that the pixels were skin and the speakers were breath and the distance was a temporary problem that love would eventually solve.

It didn't solve it. Love never solves geography. But it made the geography survivable.

Every morning, after I'd hung up, after she'd gone back to whatever her husband demanded and I'd gone back to whatever silence Priya offered, I'd lie in bed and stare at the ceiling and think:

I am living two lives. One where I'm invisible. And one where I'm the only thing she sees.

The invisible one pays the mortgage. But the other one, the one on the phone at 2 AM, that one is real. That one breathes.

* * *

Text Message — Priya to Ari August 19, 2018

Priya: You were up late again last night.

Ari: Couldn't sleep.

Priya: Okay.

* * *

She didn't ask why. She didn't want to know. And I didn't offer.

Two people in the same house, keeping the same secret for different reasons. She didn't ask because knowing would require caring. I didn't tell because telling would require admitting that my deepest relationship was happening through a screen with a woman in India while my wife slept twelve feet away.

We were both liars. Just different kinds.

* * *

The cruelest part wasn't the distance. The cruelest part was the contrast.

Every night, Meera would tell me about her husband. The forced sex. The indifference. He'd finish and roll over without a word, like she was a task he'd completed. A chore. A thing.

And I'd hold her through the phone, make her feel beautiful, make her body hers again, and then hang up. And walk to my bedroom. And lie down next to a woman who treated me with the same indifference Meera's husband showed after sex. Not violent. Just... absent.

She was drowning in too much unwanted touch. I was dying from none.

We found each other in the middle. Two people perfectly designed to heal each other's specific wound. The man who was desperate to give found the woman who was desperate to receive. The woman who needed tenderness found the man who had nothing but tenderness to offer.

It was beautiful. It was unsustainable. And it was already more real than anything either of us had known.

* * *

WhatsApp Message *August 31, 2018, 4:02 AM PST*

Meera: One month.

Ari: One month.

Meera: One hundred and thirty-seven hours on the phone. I counted.

Ari: I'm surprised it wasn't more.

Meera: What happens now?

Ari: We keep going.

Meera: And if we can't?

Ari: Then we'll have had one month where we were both alive. And that's more than most people get in a lifetime.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 6: THE CROSSING

* * *

WhatsApp Voice Note — Meera to Ari *February 12, 2019, 1:43 AM PST Duration: 1:22*

[Crying. Not the quiet kind. The kind that comes from a place so deep it doesn't care who hears it.]

“He was normal all day. That’s the thing. He was laughing with his friends. Helping his mother in the kitchen. Being the perfect son, the perfect husband, the perfect man. And then the door closed. And he just... switched. Grabbed me. Pushed me on the bed. I said no. I said it three times. No. No. No. Three times and he didn’t hear any of them.”

[Long pause. Breathing.]

“I feel dirty. I showered twice and I still feel him on me. I can’t get clean. I can’t—”

[Voice breaks.]

“Please talk to me. Please. I need your voice right now. I need something that doesn’t hurt.”

[End of voice note.]

* * *

I booked the flight thirty minutes after hearing that voice note.

Not a week later. Not after thinking about it. Not after weighing the consequences, the cost, the risk, the lies I'd have to tell Priya. Thirty minutes. That's how long it took to find a flight from Seattle to India, put it on my credit card, and close the laptop.

Some decisions aren't decisions. They're reflexes. Your body moves before your brain catches up, and by the time reason shows up to negotiate, you're already at the gate.

* * *

Flight Confirmation — Alaska Airlines / Air India *Booked: February 12, 2019, 2:17 AM PST*

Passenger: Arivazhagan Velmurugan Route: SEA → DEL → [redacted] Departure: February 28, 2019
Return: March 3, 2019 Class: Economy Total:
\$1,247.00

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *February 12, 2019*

Ari: I'm coming.

Meera: What?

Ari: To India. I booked a flight. February 28.

Meera: You're joking.

Ari: I've never been more serious about anything in my life.

Meera: Ari... you can't. What about Priya? What about work? What about—

Ari: I just listened to you cry about being raped and you're asking me about logistics?

Meera: ...

Ari: I'm coming. End of discussion.

Meera: 🥺🥺🥺

Meera: No one has ever done anything like this for me.

Ari: That ends now.

* * *

Two weeks. I had two weeks to construct a lie convincing enough to cover a trip to India.

I told Priya I had a work conference in San Francisco. Three days. She didn't ask which conference. Didn't ask the hotel name. Didn't ask why I was packing a suit I never wore. She just said "okay," like a door closing softly.

I told my manager I needed personal days. Family matter. He approved it without questions because I'd

never taken a sick day in two years and the guilt of that streak bought me three days of silence.

The lies were easy. That should have bothered me more than it did.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App *February 27, 2019, 11:48 PM*

"Tomorrow I get on a plane and fly eight thousand miles to hold a woman who isn't my wife. I should feel guilty. I do feel guilty. But the guilt is a small thing sitting next to a much larger thing, and the larger thing is: she needs me. Not my voice through a speaker. Not my words in a chat. ME. My actual hands. My actual arms. My actual body between her and whatever comes through that bedroom door at night."

"I know what I'm doing. I know what this makes me. I know."

"I'm going anyway."

* * *

In-Flight — Somewhere Over the Pacific

Fourteen hours in a middle seat. I didn't sleep. Didn't watch a movie. Didn't read. I just sat there, vibrating, thinking about what was about to happen.

Seven months. We'd been talking for seven months. Every day. Hundreds of hours of calls. Thousands of messages. We'd made love through screens more times than I could count. I'd watched her come and cry and laugh and undress and discover herself. All through a five-inch rectangle of glass.

Now I was going to touch her. For real. For the first time.

My hands were shaking. Not from turbulence. From the magnitude of it. From the knowledge that in approximately fourteen hours, eight thousand miles of distance would collapse into zero, and the woman I'd been loving through technology would become flesh and blood and breath and warmth.

I kept looking at my hands. These hands that had held a phone during every call. That had typed "you're beautiful" and "I'm here" and "let go" a thousand times. In a few hours, these same hands would be on her skin. Actual skin. Warm. Real. Alive.

I wasn't ready.

I'd never been more ready for anything in my life.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *March 1, 2019 — Day of arrival*

Ari: Landed.

Meera: I can't breathe.

Ari: [Hotel name]. Room 412. I'll be there in an hour.

Meera: I'm already in the lobby.

* * *

She was already there. An hour early. Sitting in the lobby of a hotel in her own city, waiting for a man she'd loved for seven months and never touched.

* * *

Hotel — Room 412

"Hi," she said.

The same "hi" from the first video call. But this time I could hear it without speakers. This time the sound traveled through actual air, not fiber optic cable. This time it landed on my ears, not my earbuds.

"Hi," I said.

I crossed the room. I held her.

* * *

Not a hug. Not the polite kind where you pat someone's back and step away. I HELD her. Arms around her waist, pulling her in, her face against my chest, my chin on top of her head. The way you hold someone when holding them is the only thing keeping both of you upright.

She melted.

That's not a metaphor. Her body physically softened. Every muscle that had been clenched for years, from the fear, from the rapes, from the constant vigilance of living with a man who took without asking, just... released. I felt it happen. A wave of tension leaving her body the way air leaves a balloon. And what was left was just her. Soft. Small. Real. Mine.

She was shaking. Not from cold. From the overwhelm of being held by someone safe. Someone who had flown eight thousand miles not to take, but to give.

I kissed her neck. Softly. Just below her ear. The spot I'd talked about in hundreds of video calls. The spot I'd described touching while she came from my words alone. And now my actual lips were on her actual skin, and the reality of it was so much bigger than the fantasy that we both started crying.

She melted in my arms.

Seven months of screens dissolved in a single embrace.

* * *

I didn't push. I didn't rush. I didn't let the seven months of wanting override the awareness of what she'd been through.

This woman's body had been used as a thing. Grabbed. Forced. Entered without permission. Her experience of male hands was violence. Now my hands were on her, and I needed them to feel different. Not just different from her husband. Different from every man who'd ever treated a woman's body as something to take.

So I waited.

We lay on the bed. Clothed. Just holding each other. Her head on my chest. My hand in her hair. The sound of her breathing slowing from panicked to peaceful. Real-time healing, measured in breaths.

She looked up at me.

"I thought this would be scary," she said. "Being alone with a man in a room."

"Is it?"

She shook her head. "It's the safest I've ever felt."

* * *

Later, I don't know how much later, time had stopped behaving normally. I touched her. Not sexually. Not yet. I ran my hand down her arm. Over her hip. Along the outside of her thigh. Learning her geography through fingertips instead of pixels.

Her breath hitched. Not from fear. From the novelty of being touched by someone who was paying attention. Someone who wasn't rushing toward an ending. Someone for whom the touching itself was the point.

I slid my hand between her thighs. Over her shorts. Over the fabric. I could feel the warmth of her through the cotton. I could feel her body responding, not to pressure, not to force, but to the permission I was offering without words: *this is yours. This pleasure belongs to you. I'm just here to help you find it.*

She pressed against my hand. A small movement. Almost involuntary. Like her body was answering a question before her mind could debate it.

"Is this okay?" I whispered.

"Yes," she breathed. "Please don't stop."

I didn't stop.

I rubbed her slowly. Over her panties. Not pulling them aside. Not rushing to skin. Just pressure.

Warmth. Rhythm. The patience of a man who understood that for this woman, patience was a revolutionary act.

She came. Hard. Harder than I'd ever seen on video. Her whole body seized, then released, then seized again. Her hand gripping my forearm so tight her nails left marks. Her mouth open. The sound, God, the sound, a cry that was seven months of longing and years of violation and one perfect moment of being touched by someone who gave a damn.

She came, and I held her, and she cried into my chest, and I didn't say a word. Because there were no words for this. There was only the fact of it: a woman, in a man's arms, discovering for the first time that touch could be a gift instead of a theft.

* * *

WhatsApp Message — Meera to her best friend
(She showed me this later)

Meera: I think I just understood what sex is supposed to feel like.

Friend: What happened?? Tell me everything

Meera: He didn't even take my clothes off. And it was more intimate than anything that's ever happened to me.

* * *

Day one ended with her asleep on my chest. Still clothed. Still crying, even in sleep, small involuntary tears that leaked from the corners of her closed eyes like her body was releasing poison. I didn't sleep. I just held her and listened to her breathe and thought:

I flew eight thousand miles for this. For a woman asleep on my chest, crying tears of relief. And I would fly twelve thousand more.

Day two and three... that's when she opened the rest of the doors. But that's the next chapter.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 7: THE FIRST NIGHT

* * *

Uber Receipt *March 1, 2019*

Pickup: [Redacted] International Airport Dropoff:
Hotel [Redacted], Room 412 Distance: 14.2 km
Duration: 47 minutes Fare: ₹387

* * *

Forty-seven minutes in the back of an Uber that smelled like incense and old upholstery, and I almost asked the driver to turn around three times.

Not because I didn't want to see her. Because I wanted it too much. Seven months of wanting compressed into a forty-seven-minute car ride through a city I'd never seen, and my body couldn't decide if it was excited or terrified, so it settled on both. My leg was bouncing. My hands were wet. I was wearing the shirt I'd tried on four times at home and the cologne I'd bought specifically for this trip, which now, in the back of an Indian Uber with the windows down and

the heat pressing in, seemed like the most ridiculous purchase of my life.

The driver was playing A.R. Rahman. Of course he was. The universe has a sick sense of humor. “Tere Bina” from Guru, the exact kind of sweeping romantic melody that would score the montage version of what I was doing. Man flies across ocean for woman. Strings swell. Audience cries.

In the actual version, the man is sweating through his good shirt and Googling “how to stop hands from shaking” at a red light.

* * *

The city hit me like a wall.

Not the heat, although that too. The density. The noise. The specific chaos of an Indian city that Americans can’t understand until they’re inside it. Horns that aren’t angry, just conversational. Auto-rickshaws cutting across three lanes like lane markings are decorative suggestions. A cow standing in the middle of a roundabout with the calm authority of a traffic cop who’s given up.

I’d grown up in Pondicherry. I knew India. But I’d been in Seattle for fifteen years, and fifteen years of traffic lights and right-of-way and people apologizing

for standing too close had reprogrammed my nervous system. Every near-miss made me grab the door handle. The driver noticed.

“First time, sir?”

“No. I grew up here. Just been away.”

He grinned in the rearview mirror. “India doesn’t wait for you to come back, sir. She just keeps going.”

Fair enough.

* * *

The hotel was high-range. Not crowded. Marble floors in the lobby and the man at reception calls you “sir” with genuine warmth and hands you a room key.

Hotel lobby. Lined with expensive couches. I scanned the couches walking urgently, my legs needed to move. Each couch a countdown. End of the lobby. Long hallway. Air conditioner humming. The carpet was maroon with gold patterns that had been walked into surrender. I then saw her sitting, in a yellow salwar. My eyes arrested on her as she sprung up. No time for pleasantries in public — it was still her own city and anyone seeing her with another man would mean scrutiny. I asked her to come with me and she followed like she was in a trance.

We stood silent in the elevator for thirty seconds. Our hands grazing each other's. The same hands that had held a phone during seven months of calls. The same fingers that had typed "you're beautiful" and "I'm here" and "let go." In thirty seconds, those fingers became real to each other for the first time.

I swiped the key. Pushed the door.

We are both now standing in the middle of the room.

* * *

But this chapter is about the night. The hours between the hug and falling asleep. The hours nobody writes about because they're not cinematic enough for the highlight reel.

They were the best hours of my life.

* * *

After the hug, after the crying, after the first kiss that tasted like hotel toothpaste and salt, we did something ordinary.

We ordered room service.

She wanted biryani. I wanted dosa. The menu had both, plus fourteen other things I hadn't eaten since

leaving India. I ordered too much. Way too much. Biryani, dosa, raita, gulab jamun, chai, and a Thums Up because some things you don't drink for the taste, you drink for the memory.

"You ordered for six people," she said, watching the waiter wheel in a cart that barely fit through the door.

"I haven't had real biryani in two years."

"Seattle doesn't have biryani?"

"Seattle has biryani the way Seattle has summer. Technically. But not really."

She laughed. Full. Loud. From her stomach, not her throat. I'd heard her laugh on video calls a hundred times, but the in-person version was different. It filled the room. It bounced off the walls and the bad art above the bed and the window that looked out onto a city that was still honking at 10 PM.

We sat on the bed with the food between us. Cross-legged. Plates on the bedspread. She ate with her hands. I ate with my hands. Biryani rice on the hotel sheets. Raita dripping onto the pillow. She reached across to steal a piece of my dosa and knocked over the chai.

"Oh God, the sheets—"

"They're already destroyed. Eat."

She ate. We both ate. The flavors were too strong after years of Seattle's polite cuisine. The biryani was

aggressive. The chai was a dare. My tongue burned and I didn't care.

She had rice on her chin. I didn't tell her for ten minutes because watching her eat without caring what she looked like was better than anything I'd seen since landing.

"You have rice on your chin."

"How long?"

"Since the second bite."

"And you just watched? Dei." She threw a piece of gulab jamun at me. It hit my chest and left a syrup stain on the good shirt. The shirt I'd tried on four times.

"This shirt cost me forty dollars."

"It cost you forty dollars to sit on a bed eating biryani with a married woman in India. You overpaid."

* * *

We didn't have sex that night.

The truth is simpler. And better.

We talked. For five hours. In the same room.

Without a screen between us.

You have to understand what that meant. Seven months of a rectangle between us. Seven months of her face in 1080p, pixelated when the WiFi dropped,

frozen mid-sentence when the connection lagged. Seven months of “can you hear me?” and “you’re breaking up” and “wait, say that again, the audio cut.”

Now she was three feet away and I could hear her BREATHE. Not through a speaker. Through air. The actual vibration of her actual lungs pushing actual oxygen into the actual room where I was sitting.

I could hear her swallow her chai. I could hear her fingers rustling the bedspread. I could hear the small click of her tongue against the roof of her mouth when she was thinking. Sounds that a phone murders. Sounds that only exist in proximity.

* * *

We talked about her mother.

“She makes the best sambar in three districts,” Meera said. “Not a compliment. A census fact. People have driven forty minutes for her sambar.”

“That’s love.”

“That’s a Tamil woman. There’s no difference.”

Her mother didn’t know about Vikram. Not the real version. She knew the public Vikram. The charming one. The good-family one. The one who brought sweets on Diwali and touched her mother’s feet with such perfect devotion that Meera wanted to scream.

“She’d never believe me,” Meera said quietly. “If I told her what happens behind the door. She’d say I must be provoking him. Or exaggerating. Or not being a good enough wife.”

“Is that what she’d actually say?”

“It’s what her generation says. When a marriage fails, it’s the woman’s fault. When a man is violent, the woman drove him to it. When a woman leaves, she destroyed the family.” She paused. “It’s not cruelty. It’s training. They were trained to endure, so they think endurance is love. And if you can’t endure, you’re weak.”

“You’re not weak.”

“I know that when I’m talking to you. I forget it when I hang up.”

* * *

We talked about my father.

“He’s a quiet man,” I said. “Comes home at the same time every night. Eats what my mother cooks. Watches the news. Goes to bed. Twenty-five years of marriage and I’ve never once heard him raise his voice.”

“That sounds peaceful.”

“I used to think it was boring. The absence of passion. Now I’m not so sure. Maybe showing up the same way every day is its own kind of love. The kind I never learned.”

“Is that what you’re doing now? With me? Trying to learn?”

“No. With you, the pain already caught up. You’re the part that comes after.”

She was quiet for a long time. Then she reached across the demolished room service tray and took my hand. Not romantically. Just took it. The way you hold onto something when the current is strong and the ground is shifting.

We sat like that. Holding hands over cold biryani and spilled chai. The city honking below. The fan turning above. Two married people in a hotel room who hadn’t done anything the world would call wrong, and who both knew that what they were doing was more right than anything either of them had felt in years.

* * *

She fell asleep at 3 AM.

Mid-sentence. Talking about a teacher she’d loved in school who used to say “Meera, your problem is that

you feel everything twice.” Eyes open, then half-closed, then closed. Voice fading from words to murmurs to breath.

I caught the chai cup before it tipped. Moved the plates to the desk. Pulled the blanket over her without disturbing the position she’d fallen into, curled on her side, face toward me, one hand still reaching across the space where my hand had been.

I didn’t sleep.

I sat in the chair by the window and looked at her. Not in a creepy way. In the way you look at something you’ve only seen through glass and now, suddenly, impossibly, the glass is gone.

She was smaller in person. On the screen she was everything. In this room she was just a woman. Just bones and skin and a face that twitched in sleep and a mouth that fell slightly open and a body that curled into itself like it was still protecting against something, even in dreams.

The room smelled like biryani and chai and her. Jasmine. Not perfume. Her skin. Some people just smell like things. She smelled like jasmine and sleep and the faintest trace of sweat from the heat that the AC couldn’t fully beat.

Outside, the city was quieting. Indian cities don’t go silent. They just lower the volume. From a scream

to a hum. Auto-rickshaws became distant. Horns became occasional. Dogs took over the night shift, barking at things only dogs can see.

I sat in that chair and I thought: I have to go back. In two days. To Seattle. To the silent house. To Priya facing the wall. To the couch. To the phone that, starting in forty-eight hours, will be the only way I can reach this woman again.

But not yet. Not tonight. Tonight she's here. Real. Breathing. Three feet away with biryani rice still on the sheets and a half-finished story about a teacher who said she feels everything twice.

The teacher was right. Meera feels everything twice. Once when it happens. Once when she remembers.

I was watching her make a memory. And I was making one too.

* * *

Hotel Room 412 — March 2, 2019 — 6:17 AM

She woke up before me.

I know this because when I opened my eyes — I'd fallen asleep in the chair, neck bent at an angle that would punish me for days — she was already looking at me.

“How long have you been watching me?” I asked.
“Long enough to make sure you’re real,” she said.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 8: THREE DAYS

* * *

Hotel Room 412 — Day Two

She woke up before me.

I know this because when I opened my eyes, she was already looking at me. Not at her phone. Not at the ceiling. At me. Studying my face how I used to study her photos, like she was memorizing something she was afraid she'd lose.

“How long have you been watching me?” I asked.

“Long enough to make sure you're real,” she said.

There was already coffee on the bedside table. A small steel tumbler, filter coffee, the kind you can only get in South India, the kind that tastes like someone's grandmother distilled love into a dark liquid and served it in metal because metal is honest. She'd ordered it while I was sleeping. Called room service. Whispered so she wouldn't wake me. Then gotten back into bed and pretended to be asleep so I wouldn't know.

I knew because the coffee was still hot. And because her breathing was too even — the studied

breathing of a woman pretending to sleep, which is different from actual sleep the way a photograph of a river is different from a river.

“You ordered for me.”

“You talk in your sleep about filter coffee. It wasn’t hard to guess.”

I drank the coffee sitting up in bed while the Chennai morning pushed through curtains that didn’t quite close. She lay beside me on her stomach, chin propped on her folded arms, watching me drink coffee the way you watch something you want to memorize.

“I just like watching you do normal things,” she said. “You’ve only ever been a voice. A screen. A two-dimensional beautiful thing I talked to in the dark. Watching you drink coffee makes you three-dimensional.”

“I was always real.”

“I know. But knowing and seeing are different languages.”

* * *

She showered first. She sang — softly, *Snehithane* from Alaipayuthey — and her voice bounced off the bathroom tiles and leaked through the door. I sat on the bed listening and thought: I’ve heard her voice

through a phone for seven months. Through speakers. Through earbuds at 2 AM. But I've never heard it through a door. The door meant she was HERE. Six feet away instead of eight thousand miles.

* * *

Day two was different. Something had shifted overnight. The woman who'd been trembling in the lobby was gone. In her place was someone braver. Someone who'd slept in safe arms for the first time in years and woke up hungry for more.

She kissed me first.

That matters. She initiated. Not me. After years of a man taking without asking, she reached for me. She chose. And the choosing was everything.

* * *

It started slow. Her lips on mine. Tentative. Testing. Careful. Ready to pull back at the first sign of pain. But there was no pain. Just warmth. Just the taste of hotel toothpaste and morning breath and the sweetest imperfection of a real kiss after seven months of imagining one.

She pulled back. Looked at me. Searching for something, permission maybe. Or confirmation that she wasn't dreaming.

"More," she whispered.

So I gave her more.

I kissed her exactly as I'd described in a hundred video calls. Slow. Deliberate. Starting with her lips, then her jaw, then her neck, that spot below her ear I'd been naming as mine for months through words. Now with actual lips. Actual breath. Actual tongue.

She arched into me. A sound escaped her, half gasp, half laugh, the sound of a body remembering what pleasure felt like when it wasn't stolen.

"I want to feel you," she said. "All of you. No clothes."

* * *

We undressed each other.

Not frantically. Not with buttons flying and fabric tearing. We undressed each other like we were unwrapping something sacred.

I pulled her shirt over her head. She lifted her arms to help. Her skin was warm and brown, and I had to stop and just look at her because the screen had never done her justice. Not even close. Softer. Fuller. More

alive. The warmth of her. The small imperfections that made her real. How she breathed differently when she was exposed.

She was shy. Of course she was. Her body had been a battleground for years. Letting someone see it by choice, in daylight, with the curtains open. That was an act of war against everything her husband had taught her about her own body.

“You’re beautiful,” I said. And then felt stupid for saying it like that, like a line from something. But I didn’t take it back.

Her shoulders dropped. Her arms stopped hovering near her stomach. She let me look.

Then she undressed me. Her hands shaking. Not from fear. From want. She’d watched me on screen dozens of times. But touching real skin under her palm was new. Her fingers traced my chest like a blind person reads braille. Learning. Memorizing.

“You’re warm,” she said. Like it surprised her. Like she’d forgotten that men could be warm.

* * *

We made love.

Not had sex. Not fucked. Made love.

She was nervous. I was nervous. Neither of us had been with anyone new in years. — her because her husband was the only body she knew, me because Priya had made intimacy impossible.

I entered her slowly, watching for any sign that the room had become his room. It hadn't. She said my name.

“Don't stop,” she whispered. “Please. Stay.”

I stayed.

* * *

Late afternoon. Golden light through the hotel curtains. We were both exhausted and raw and open in a way that only comes after you've cried and come and laughed and cried again. She was lying on her side, facing me. I traced the curve of her waist with my fingers. She traced my jaw with hers. We looked at each other for a long time without speaking.

Then she pulled me into her. No words. Just her hand on the back of my neck, guiding my mouth to hers, and her body opening, and the slowest, deepest lovemaking of my life. The kind where you don't move so much as breathe together.

She fell asleep inside my arms. I stayed inside her. Neither of us wanted to separate. We'd been separated

for seven months by an ocean. Now even an inch felt like too much.

* * *

Day Three

Day three was the last day. We both knew it. The return flight was booked. The lie to Priya had an expiration date. The hotel room that had become our entire world was about to become a memory.

There's a specific kind of desperation that comes with borrowed time. You don't waste it. You don't spend it on small talk or room service or scrolling your phone. You spend it on the thing that matters most.

She was different on day three. Bolder. Like she'd decided overnight that if this was the last time, she was going to leave nothing behind. No fear. No shame. No held-back corners of herself.

"I want to feel everything," she said. "No barriers."
She meant it literally.

* * *

I'd used protection the first two days. Neither of us was thinking clearly about logistics. Not from planning —

some part of my brain had remembered to pack condoms.

Day three, she said no.

“I want to feel YOU,” she said. “Not latex. You.”

I looked at her. She looked at me. We both understood what we were doing. The risk. The recklessness. The trust required to take that risk together.

“Are you sure?”

“I’ve never been more sure of anything.”

* * *

Raw. Inside her. Nothing between us.

And it was different. We both felt it. The absence of the barrier was a presence of its own. Not latex. Not screens. Not oceans. Nothing.

She wrapped her legs around me. Not to hold me there. To hold me closer. Her heels pressing into the small of my back. Her arms around my neck. Her face buried in my shoulder.

“Don’t pull out,” she whispered. “I want all of you.”

I came inside her. Deep. And she held me there, tight, both of us shaking, both of us knowing that what we’d just done couldn’t be undone. That I was inside her in a way that no distance could reverse.

She cried. I cried. The sheets were a mess of tears and sweat and us.

* * *

WhatsApp Message — Ari to Meera *Written in the taxi to the airport. Never sent. Saved in drafts.*

“Three days. That’s what the universe gave us. Three days to hold what we’ve been building through screens for seven months. Three days to give your body back to you and lose mine in the process.”

“I’m in a taxi and you’re getting smaller in the rearview mirror of a city I’ll probably never see again. And I can still feel you on my skin. I can still smell your hair on my shirt. I’m carrying you home with me in every cell.”

“Three days is not enough.”

“But three days is what we got. And they were the realest days of my life.”

* * *

The taxi pulled away from the hotel. I didn’t look back. If I looked back, I’d tell the driver to stop. And if I stopped, I’d never leave. And if I never left, the lie would collapse, and Priya would know, and the world

I'd built in Seattle, the career, the house, the marriage that was already dead but still standing, would crumble.

So I looked forward. At the road. At the airport signs. At the departure board that said SEA like it was just a destination and not the ocean that was about to swallow everything we'd built.

I boarded the plane. Found my middle seat. Put in my earbuds. Opened WhatsApp.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *March 3, 2019 — In-flight*

Meera: Are you on the plane?

Ari: Yes.

Meera: I can still feel you inside me.

Ari: I can still feel you around me.

Meera: When are you coming back?

Ari: I don't know.

Meera: Promise me you'll come back.

Ari: I promise.

Meera: I love you.

Ari: I love you. More than this plane can carry.

* * *

I closed my eyes somewhere over the Arabian Sea and slept for the first time in three days. When I woke up, we were over the Pacific. Eight thousand miles from her. Twelve hours from Priya.

Going back to the silence.

But this time, the silence had a crack in it. Three days wide. And through that crack, I could still hear her breathing.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 9: THE RETURN

★ *Meera's POV*

* * *

Auto-Rickshaw Meter *March 3, 2019*

Start: Hotel [Redacted] End: [Home address] Fare:
₹142

* * *

The auto-rickshaw driver talked the entire ride. About the weather. About his daughter's school fees. About how the city was building a new flyover that would ruin his shortcut. Meera heard none of it. She nodded at the right intervals because Tamil women are trained to nod at men who are talking, but her mind was in a hotel room that was getting farther away with every pothole.

She could still feel him.

Not poetically. Physically. Between her legs. On her neck where his mouth had been. In the muscles of her thighs that hadn't unclenched since yesterday. She'd showered at the hotel before leaving, standing under

water that was barely warm, scrubbing with the tiny soap, trying to wash away the evidence. Not because she was ashamed. Because she had to walk back into a house where a man with a different nose would sleep next to her tonight, and that man could not smell what she smelled like right now.

She smelled like Ari. Like his cologne and his sweat and the particular scent of a man who touches you like you're something he found, not something he owns. She scrubbed until her skin was pink. It wasn't enough. She could still smell him under the soap, in her hair, in the places the water couldn't reach.

Good, she thought. Then corrected herself. Dangerous.

* * *

The auto-rickshaw turned onto her street and her body changed.

She felt it happen. A physical shift, like a door closing inside her chest. Her shoulders rose. Her jaw tightened. Her hands, which had been loose in her lap, curled into fists around the fabric of her churidar. The woman who'd spent three days laughing in a hotel room was packing herself away, folding herself into the smaller shape that fit inside this house.

She paid the driver. He gave her too little change. She didn't argue. Tamil women don't argue with auto-rickshaw drivers. Tamil women don't argue.

The front door was blue. She'd never noticed how ugly it was. Three days away and suddenly her own front door looked like what it was: the entrance to a cage she'd decorated to look like a home.

She turned the key.

* * *

Inside

The house smelled like sambar. Her mother-in-law had been cooking. That was the first thing. The second thing was the television. Cricket. Always cricket. The third thing was Vikram's chappals by the door, placed neatly, toes pointing out, like a man who had his life in order.

"You're back," he said from the couch. Not a question. Not warm. Just a timestamp. You were gone. Now you're here. The absence has been noted.

"Traffic was bad," she said. The lie she'd prepared. She'd told him she was visiting her college friend in Chennai. Three days. He hadn't asked which friend. Hadn't asked for the address. Hadn't offered to drive her. He'd said "okay" and gone back to his cricket, and

she'd packed a bag with trembling hands and walked out of the house carrying three days' worth of clothes and seven months' worth of longing.

"Amma made sambar," he said. "Eat."

Not "are you hungry." Not "how was your trip." Not "I missed you." Just: eat. A command dressed as information.

"I ate on the way," she said. Another lie. She hadn't eaten since the hotel. Since Ari fed her gulab jamun with his fingers at 2 AM and she'd laughed so hard the syrup dripped down her chin and he'd kissed it off and she'd thought: this is what happy tastes like. Sugar and someone else's mouth.

Now she was home. And happy tasted like sambar she didn't want, cooked by a mother-in-law who monitored her like a security camera with a prayer schedule.

* * *

She went to the bedroom. Their bedroom. Put her bag down. Sat on the bed.

This bed.

Three days ago she'd been on a different bed. White sheets. His arms around her. His voice in her ear saying things that made her body do things she'd never

known it could. She'd cried and laughed and come and cried again. She'd fallen asleep on his chest and woken up safe.

This bed had the same color sheets. Some cosmic joke. White sheets here, white sheets there. But these white sheets were the ones Vikram pulled back every night. These were the sheets where he climbed on top of her and she went to the ceiling and waited for it to end.

She sat on the bed and pressed her palms into the mattress and thought: I just had the best three days of my life and now I'm sitting on the bed where my husband rapes me and I have to pretend everything is normal and I have to eat sambar and I have to smile at his mother and I have to sleep next to him tonight and if he reaches for me I will have to let him because saying no has never worked and tonight it will be worse because my body still belongs to someone else and he'll be inside me and I'll be in that hotel room and I'll hate every second and I can't tell anyone, not one person on this earth except the man who just got in a taxi to the airport, and he's gone.

She didn't cry. She was past crying. Crying was for women who still expected things to be different. She'd stopped expecting. What she'd started doing, in the

last three days, was something more dangerous than expecting.

She'd started knowing.

She knew what love felt like now. What touch felt like when it wasn't a transaction. What sex felt like when it was a gift instead of a taking. She knew because a man had shown her in a hotel room with gulab jamun on the sheets and a forty-dollar shirt with a syrup stain.

And knowing was the cruelest thing he could have given her. Because before Ari, she could endure. Endurance is easy when you don't know what you're missing. You can survive a dark room forever if you've never seen light.

He'd shown her light. And now she had to go back to the dark room. And the dark room was worse now. Worse because she knew. Worse because every time Vikram touched her, she'd compare. Every time he finished in ninety seconds and rolled over, she'd remember a man who spent forty-five minutes just on her neck. Every time she went to the ceiling, she'd remember what it felt like to stay in her body. To be present. To want to be there.

* * *

Vikram came to bed at 11.

She heard his footsteps. The bathroom. The flush. The tap. The gargle. The same sequence every night for four years. She could time it with her eyes closed. Fourteen steps from the living room. Bathroom door. Ninety seconds. Flush. Tap for thirty seconds. Gargle. Spit. Tap again. Door. Six steps to the bed. Mattress dip.

He lay down. She was facing the wall. She'd learned to face the wall years ago. Facing him was an invitation. The wall was a boundary he sometimes respected.

Tonight he didn't.

His hand on her hip. Heavy. Not gentle. The hand of a man reaching for something he considers his. Like reaching for the remote. Like opening the fridge. Automatic. Entitled.

"I'm tired," she said.

"You've been gone three days. Doing what? Sitting?"

"It was a long drive back."

His hand didn't move. It squeezed. Not painfully. Possessively. The way you squeeze a fruit to check if it's ripe.

"Five minutes," he said. As if that was a concession. As if brevity was the same as consent.

She didn't say no again. Saying no once was the allowance. Saying it twice was a provocation. She'd learned the math.

She went to the ceiling.

It took him less than five minutes. He didn't notice she was gone. He never noticed. He finished, rolled over, and within four minutes his breathing was the deep, unbothered rhythm of a man who sleeps well because he's never questioned whether the body next to him wanted to be there.

Meera lay in the dark. His residue between her legs. Ari's memory between her ribs. Two men's fingerprints on the same body in the same week, and the distance between those fingerprints was the distance between everything she was surviving and everything she was living for.

She picked up her phone from the nightstand. Opened WhatsApp.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *March 3, 2019, 11:48 PM IST*

Meera: Are you on the plane?

Ari: Yes.

Meera: I can still feel you inside me.

* * *

She typed that in bed. Next to her husband. Who was asleep. Who had been inside her twenty minutes ago. Who would never know that the woman next to him was texting the man she actually loved, telling him she could still feel him, while the evidence of a different man dried on the sheets.

She should have felt guilty. She searched for it. Rummaged through her emotions like a woman going through a purse looking for keys. Guilt? No. Shame? No. Fear? Yes, always, but not about this. Relief? Yes. A deep, bone-level relief that the hotel existed. That the three days existed. That somewhere in the world, a man was flying home carrying the knowledge of her body, and that knowledge was a kind of freedom, even if the cage was still locked.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *March 3, 2019, 11:52 PM IST*

Ari: I can still feel you around me.

Meera: When are you coming back?

Ari: I don't know.

Meera: Promise me you'll come back.

Ari: I promise.

Meera: I love you.

Ari: I love you. More than this plane can carry.

* * *

She read “more than this plane can carry” and smiled in the dark. The same dark where Vikram snored. The same dark where she’d go to the ceiling. The same dark that had been her whole life until a man on TikTok played a song she recognized.

She locked the phone. Put it face-down. Closed her eyes.

Tomorrow she’d wake up and be a wife again. She’d make coffee for Vikram’s mother. She’d smile at the right moments. She’d clear her search history and delete the call logs and carry the secret of three days in a hotel like a stone in her pocket that nobody could see but she could always feel.

Tomorrow the performance would resume.

But tonight, for five more minutes, she let herself stay in the hotel room. White sheets. Gulab jamun. A man’s voice saying “let go” like it was the simplest thing in the world.

She fell asleep in two places at once.

* * *

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* * *

PART THREE: THE EARTHQUAKE

March 2019 – 2020

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CHAPTER 10: THE EARTHQUAKE

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WhatsApp Message *March 18, 2019, 11:47 PM PST*

Meera: I need to tell you something.

* * *

Four words that stop a heart.

Not “I love you”: those four words accelerate it. Not “I miss you”: those make it ache in a warm way. But “I need to tell you something” — that’s a four-word cardiac arrest. Because whatever follows is going to change the shape of everything that came before.

I was sitting in my car. In the driveway. Engine off. The house dark behind me. Priya asleep.

I’d learned to sit in the driveway. Not because the house wasn’t available to me — I paid for it, my name was on the mortgage, my clothes were in the closet. But the house had become a place with a specific emotional weather, and I needed twenty minutes in the car to adjust to it before I walked in. The kitchen would be clean, wiped down, everything put away. Not

for me. For her, for our daughter, for the order she maintained with a precision that had nothing to do with my comfort. My plate was not on the table. It hadn't been for years. If I was hungry I made something or I didn't. She didn't ask. I didn't mention it. That was the agreement nobody had spoken aloud.

I'd been sitting there for twenty minutes doing what I did every night, decompressing from the life I lived inside the house before switching to the life I lived on my phone. The transition took longer each time.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *March 18, 2019*

Ari: Tell me.

Meera: I'm pregnant.

* * *

The driveway disappeared. The car disappeared. The house, the dark windows, the sleeping wife. All of it collapsed into two words on a screen.

Pregnant.

Two weeks after I left India. Two weeks after day three. Two weeks after I came inside her, raw, deep,

both of us crying, both of us knowing what we were doing.

My first thought wasn't fear. It wasn't guilt. It wasn't logistics.

My first thought was: *mine*.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *March 18, 2019 — continued*

Ari: Is it... mine?

Meera: It could be. The timing is right. But...

Ari: But what?

Meera: He's been forcing me. You know that.

Around the same time. I can't be sure.

Ari: How close to the same time?

Meera: Within days. I'm sorry. I'm so sorry.

Ari: Don't apologize. This isn't your fault.

Meera: I don't know whose it is. I don't know. I'm scared.

Ari: Whatever happens, I'm here.

* * *

"It could be mine."

Those four words did something to me that nothing in my life had done before. Not the dead marriage. Not

the TikTok fame. Not the first video call. Not even the three days in the hotel. Those words reached into a part of me I didn't know existed: the part that wanted to be a father. That wanted to create something with the woman I loved. That wanted to leave something in the world that was OURS, not just a memory on a phone.

But the next sentence destroyed it just as fast: "He's been forcing me. Around the same time."

The math was cruel. She'd been raped by her husband within days of making love to me. Two men's bodies had been inside her in the same week. One by violence. One by choice. And now a child was growing, and nobody, not her or me or God, could untangle which love or which violation had created it.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App *March 19, 2019, 3:14 AM*

"She's pregnant. It might be mine."

"Five words that just rearranged every atom in my body."

"I'm sitting in a house where I eat alone and do my own laundry and sleep on a couch she didn't put me on — I put myself there, because the bedroom had

become her territory and I was no longer welcome in it. And somewhere across an ocean, a woman I love might be carrying my child. And she's also married to a man who rapes her. And the child might be his."

"This is not a life. This is a novel nobody would believe."

* * *

She was terrified. Not of the pregnancy. Of the uncertainty. Of carrying a child for nine months and looking at it every day wondering whose eyes it had. Whose hands. Whose blood.

I was terrified too. But my terror had a different flavor. Mine tasted like hope.

Because as long as the baby could be mine, it WAS mine. That's how hope works. It doesn't need certainty. It needs possibility. A crack in the door. A maybe. "It could be" was enough for my heart to build an entire future around.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages March 22, 2019

Ari: How are you feeling?

Meera: Sick. Every morning. And scared every minute.

Ari: What does he think?

Meera: He thinks it's his. Obviously. He doesn't know about you.

Ari: And you're going to let him believe that?

Meera: What choice do I have? If I tell him the truth, he'll kill me. Not metaphorically. Actually kill me.

Ari: Then we protect you. Both of you.

Meera: Both?

Ari: You and our baby.

Meera: Ari... we don't know if it's yours.

Ari: I know enough.

* * *

“Our baby.” I said it and I meant it. Even without proof. Even without certainty. Even knowing that the child could belong to the man who raped its mother. I claimed it. Because someone needed to love this baby for the right reasons, and I was the only candidate.

Her husband would love it as a possession. Another link in the chain that kept Meera tied to him. Another reason she couldn't leave. Another body in the house that he controlled.

I would love it as a miracle. As the one beautiful thing that came from the strangest, most ruinous love story either of us had ever lived.

* * *

Months passed.

The calls continued. Every day. But the texture changed. There was a weight to every conversation now, a gravity that hadn't been there before. We talked about names. Laughed about whether the baby would have my nose or her eyes. Argued gently about whether to teach it Tamil first (the correct answer, obviously — Hindi is what you learn to survive in airports and Bollywood films, Tamil is what you learn to survive in life). We debated names. She wanted something classical. I wanted something that worked in both countries. "Something a teacher in Seattle can pronounce without making it sound like a sneeze," I said. She laughed. "Americans will mispronounce anything. I once heard someone say 'chai tea latte' and wanted to call the police."

We were playing house across an ocean. Two people building a nursery in their imaginations while their real lives burned around them.

She sent me ultrasound photos.

I zoomed in. Desperately. This tiny blob of cells just becoming a person — I was pinching the screen wider and wider, squinting at the shape of the head, the curve where the ears would be, the length of the legs. Whether they were long. Whether there was anything — any curve, any angle, any half-formed feature — that looked like it could be mine. I wasn't thinking clearly. You can't tell whose genes a twelve-week ultrasound carries. But I wasn't looking for science. I was looking for evidence. Any thread of connection between me and that image. Any reason to believe this baby belonged to me.

I needed it to be mine. Not because of some abstract idea of fatherhood. Because at that moment, in that house, in that life — a maybe-daughter across an ocean was the only thing that felt like hope. The only thing that made the couch and the silence and the plate never set and the life I was living feel like it was leading somewhere. Like it meant something.

I zoomed in until the image pixelated and there was nothing left to see. And then I looked a little longer anyway.

* * *

WhatsApp Message *June 2019*

Meera: [Ultrasound photo]

Meera: Look at those tiny hands.

Ari: That's our baby.

Meera: Ari...

Ari: I know. Maybe. But let me have this.

Meera: Okay.

Meera: Our baby. With tiny hands.

* * *

She let me have it. The belief. The hope. The fatherhood that existed only in WhatsApp messages and video calls at 2 AM.

She let me have it because she knew what it meant to me. Because she knew that this man, starving for love, who flew eight thousand miles to hold her, who made her come with his voice and his patience and his presence, needed to believe he was creating something. Not just pleasure. Not just intimacy. A life.

Or maybe she let me have it because she needed me to stay. Because “the baby might be yours” was the strongest thread she could tie between us. Stronger than love. Stronger than sex. Stronger than seven months of video calls.

A possible child is the ultimate “I will, but not yet.” It keeps you hoping. It keeps you calling. It keeps you

tethered to a woman across an ocean because
somewhere in her body, something that might be half
you is growing.

I didn't see that then. I only see it now.

* * *

The baby was born in late 2019.

She sent me a photo. A tiny face. Dark hair. Closed fists. A newborn that looks like every other newborn. Ancient and new at the same time. Wrinkled like an old man who's seen too much. Carrying the features of ancestors neither parent has met, looking vaguely offended at having been born, the way all Indian babies look for the first forty-eight hours, as though they'd been perfectly comfortable where they were and didn't appreciate the eviction.

I stared at that photo for an hour. Looking for me. Looking for her. Looking for the truth.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *Late 2019*

Meera: [Baby photo]

Meera: She's here.

Ari: She's perfect.

Meera: She has your forehead.

Ari: You think so?

Meera: I think so.

* * *

“She has your forehead.”

I believed it. I needed to believe it. For four years, I carried that sentence like a talisman. A forehead. A maybe. A tiny girl across the ocean who might have my DNA and definitely had my heart.

Three years.

The child grew. Features sharpened. The truth emerged the way truth always does: slowly, then all at once.

But that comes later. For now, in late 2019, I was a man who believed he was a father. Who lived two lives: one empty, one impossible. Who loved a woman he couldn't have and a child he couldn't hold and a future he couldn't build.

It was the happiest I'd been in years.

Most deluded, too. But happiness and delusion look exactly the same from the inside.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 11: THE SILENCE

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *January 4, 2020*

Ari: Good morning. How's the baby?

Delivered. 6:02 AM PST.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *January 4, 2020*

Ari: Hey, everything okay? You haven't replied.

Delivered. 11:14 PM PST.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *January 5, 2020*

Ari: Meera?

Delivered. 7:33 AM PST.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *January 6, 2020*

Ari: Please just tell me you're okay. One word.
That's all I need.

Delivered. 2:17 AM PST.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages January 8, 2020

Ari: I'm getting scared. Please.

Delivered. 12:41 AM PST.

* * *

Delivered. Not read. Five messages over four days, and every single one stopped at “delivered.” Two grey ticks that might as well have been two middle fingers.

She was gone.

* * *

There was no warning. No fight. No “I need space.” No “I think we should talk.” One day we were on a video call at 2 AM talking about the baby’s first smile, and the next day, nothing. A wall of silence so sudden and complete it felt like someone had died.

I checked her TikTok. Still active. Posting stories. Liking videos. She wasn’t dead. She wasn’t in the hospital. She wasn’t in a place where phones don’t work. She was alive, and online, and choosing not to talk to me.

* * *

Ari's Phone — Call Log January 2020

Jan 4: Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00)
Jan 4: Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan
5: Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan 6:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan 6:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan 7:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan 8:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan 9:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan 10:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan 12:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan 15:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Jan 22:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00) Feb 1:
Outgoing call to Meera — No answer (0:00)

*Total unanswered calls: 13 Total call duration:
0:00*

* * *

Thirteen calls. Zero seconds of connection.

Each one the same ritual: open the phone. Find her name. Press call. Listen to it ring. Ring. Ring. Ring. Voicemail. Hang up. Stare at the screen. Put the phone down. Pick it up again. Almost call again. Put it down.

Repeat.

The first week, I called twice a day. By the second week, once. By the third, every few days. By February, once. Each unanswered ring was a small death, and there are only so many small deaths a person can absorb before the phone starts feeling like a weapon aimed at your own chest.

* * *

Google Search History — Ari's Browser *January 2020*

“why would someone ghost you” “ghosting after deep relationship” “she stopped replying but is still active” “is she ghosting me or is something wrong” “how to stop checking if someone is online” “why does being ghosted hurt so much” “can you die from heartbreak” (*searched at 3:47 AM*)

* * *

Can you die from heartbreak? I searched that at 3:47 in the morning, sitting on the bathroom floor because I couldn't lie in bed next to Priya while my chest was caving in. The tiles were cold. The light was

fluorescent. I was thirty-two years old and Googling whether it was possible to die from being ignored.

The answer, medically, is yes. Takotsubo cardiomyopathy. Broken heart syndrome. The heart muscle weakens from extreme emotional stress, mimicking a heart attack. It mostly affects women. But sitting on that bathroom floor, I would have argued the research.

* * *

Silence does something specific to a man who was already living in silence.

Priya didn't speak to me. That was baseline. That was the water I'd been swimming in for years. I'd adapted to that silence like chronic pain, not by healing, but by lowering my threshold for what counts as normal.

But Meera's silence was different. This was a woman who'd talked to me for four to six hours every single day for eighteen months. Who'd said "I love you" every night. Who'd come with my name on her lips. Who'd sent me ultrasound photos and said "our baby." Who'd lain naked on my chest in a hotel room and said "I've never felt this safe."

When THAT person goes silent, the silence isn't just quiet. It's an explosion played in reverse. Every conversation, every moan, every whispered "I miss you", all of it rushing backward into a void. Like someone pressed rewind on eighteen months of your life and erased the tape.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App January 14, 2020

"Day ten of nothing."

"I've started counting. I don't want to count. Counting means it's real. Counting means she's actually doing this. But I can't stop. Day ten. Two hundred and forty hours since her last message. Fourteen thousand four hundred minutes of silence."

"The baby. What about the baby? If she's gone, the baby is gone too. My maybe-daughter. The forehead that might be mine. Gone behind a wall of grey ticks."

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App January 28, 2020

"Day twenty-four."

“I drove to the grocery store today and sat in the parking lot for forty-five minutes. Didn’t go in. Just sat there. Couldn’t move. Priya called once to ask if I was getting milk. I said yes. I didn’t get milk. I didn’t get anything. I just sat in a parking lot and stared at a phone that doesn’t ring anymore.”

* * *

Ari’s Journal — iPhone Notes App *February 19, 2020*

“Day forty-six.”

“I think I know why she left. The baby. She looked at that baby and decided: I have to try. I have to make this work. For her. Not for him. For the child who needs a father in the room, not a voice on a phone.”

“And I can’t even be angry at that. Because if the baby IS mine, wouldn’t I want the same thing? Wouldn’t I want her to have a whole family, even if that family doesn’t include me?”

“Yes. I would.”

“That doesn’t stop it from killing me.”

* * *

The house got quieter. Which shouldn't have been possible. It was already the quietest place on earth. But there's a difference between the silence of a dead marriage and the silence of a dead marriage PLUS the absence of the one person who made you feel alive.

Before Meera, the house was a holding pattern. Boring. Numb. Survivable.

After Meera left, the house was a coffin. Every room a reminder of where I'd stood while talking to her. The couch where I'd called her every night. The bathroom where I'd whispered so Priya couldn't hear. The driveway where I'd sat in the car, decompressing between my two lives.

Now there was only one life. And it was the empty one.

* * *

TikTok Analytics — @ari_live99 January-March 2020

Lives hosted: 3 (*down from 28/month*) Average viewers: 89 (*down from 312*) New followers: 12 (*down from 400+/month*) Comments replied to: 0

* * *

I stopped going Live. The chat kept asking: “Where’s Ari?” “When’s the next Live?” “Bro we miss you!” But how do you make people feel seen when you can’t see anything yourself? How do you play song games when every Tamil melody reminds you of the girl who used to win them all?

The regulars noticed. @tamil_queen_88 sent a DM: “You okay bro? We’re worried.” I replied: “All good. Just busy.” The easiest lie in the world. The one everyone accepts because nobody really wants to know.

* * *

Priya noticed something too. In her own way. In the way that people who live in the same house notice a shift in temperature without being able to name it.

* * *

Text Messages — Priya to Ari *February 2020*

Priya: You seem different lately.

Ari: How so?

Priya: Quieter.

Ari: I’ve always been quiet.

Priya: Not like this.

* * *

Not like this. She was right. Before, my quiet was the steady hum of a man coping. Now my quiet was the flat line of a man who'd lost the only thing worth making noise about.

She didn't ask more. She never asked more. That was our pattern: she'd open a door an inch, I'd stand behind it, and we'd both pretend the door was closed.

* * *

Months passed. The longest months of my life. Longer than the dead years of marriage. Longer than the time zones between me and Meera. Because at least during those things, there was something to wait for. A Live to host. A call to make. A voice to hear at 2 AM.

Now there was nothing. Just the commute and the code and the couch and the ceiling and the phone that didn't ring.

I thought about Meera every day. Not in the dramatic, cinematic way. In the small, erosive way. The way water thinks about stone. Constantly. Quietly. Wearing a hole in everything it touches.

Where was she? Was the baby okay? Did the baby have my forehead? Was her husband still forcing her?

Did she think about me? Did she miss the calls? Did she lie in bed at night and reach for her phone and almost call me and then put it down?

I'll never know. Being ghosted doesn't give you answers. You get theories. And theories are just loneliness wearing a lab coat.

* * *

WhatsApp Message *March 2020 — the last one Ari sent before going silent too*

Ari: I don't know if you're reading these. I don't know if you ever will. But I want you to know: I'm not angry. I'm just here. In the same house. With the same silence. Missing you in a room where nobody notices I'm gone.

Delivered. 1:33 AM PST. Read 1:34 AM PST.

* * *

She read it. One minute after I sent it. Which means she was awake. At her phone. Looking at my name. Reading my words.

She didn't reply.

One minute. She was right there. On the other side of the screen. Close enough to see my pain in real time.

And she chose to stay silent.

That was the night I stopped sending messages.

I hadn't stopped loving her. I finally understood: she was choosing. And her choice wasn't me.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App *March 15, 2020*

"She read it. She was right there. And she said nothing."

"I think that's the real goodbye. Not the silence itself. But the proof that the silence is a choice. She's not unable to reply. She's unwilling."

"Okay."

"Okay."

"Okay."

* * *

I wrote "okay" three times because once wasn't enough to convince myself. Three times and I still didn't believe it. But I closed the journal and put down the phone and walked to the bedroom and lay down next to Priya and stared at the ceiling until morning.

The same ceiling. The same silence. But now
without even the hope of a phone that might ring.

It doesn't crash. It doesn't thunder. It just... settles.
Like dust after an earthquake. Quiet. Complete. Final.

Until it isn't.

The Live
That Ended

Ari
POV — First
Person

*[Placement:
Within Ch11
"The
Silence" — a
scene
showing the
silence year
lived, not
journalled]*

TikTok Analytics Dashboard — @ari_live99
October 2020

Followers: 31,442 Total Likes: 612,304 Average
Live Viewers: 180-220 (↓ 38% from July 2019) Most
Active Hours: Inconsistent Top Content: [No new
uploads in 14 days]

*Account flagged: Reduced posting frequency.
Consider going Live to re-engage your audience.*

* * *

I went Live on a Tuesday because the algorithm told me to.

Not because I wanted to. Not because I had something to say. Because my phone sent a notification — *Your audience misses you! Go Live to reconnect* — and the word “reconnect” hit me like a slap, because the person I wanted to reconnect with had fifty-three unanswered messages and a profile picture I’d memorized so completely I could draw it with my eyes closed.

So I went Live. At 9 PM, our old time. The time that used to be hers.

* * *

TikTok Live — @ari_live99 *October 13, 2020, 9:02 PM PST* Viewers: 47

“Hey everyone. Long time. I know, I know. Your boy’s been... away. But I’m here now. What do you want to hear?”

The chat moved. Slowly. Not the waterfall of messages from the old days. A trickle.

@tamil_queen_88: OMG you’re back! 🔥
@deepa_dreams: We missed you bro ❤️
@lonely_in_london: Play something sad
@raj_seattle: King is back

Forty-seven viewers. I used to pull three hundred on a slow night. But three hundred was when I had something to give. When the Lives were fueled by the secret energy of a man who was desired, who was loved in a language no one in the chat could hear. The audience didn't know about Meera, but they felt her. She was the electricity running beneath every joke, every song, every late-night monologue about love and loneliness and what it means to be seen.

Without her, I was a lamp unplugged. Still shaped like a thing that gives light. Giving nothing.

"Sad songs tonight," I said. "Lonely in London knows what's up."

I picked up the guitar. I'd been playing less. The guitar sat in the corner of the living room, gathering a specific kind of dust — the dust that settles on things that used to matter.

I played *Nenjukkul Peidhidum* from Vaaranam Aayiram. The song about missing someone so completely that the rain feels like their absence. Rahman composed it like a wound set to music. The first verse is fine. Manageable. A man singing about loss in the abstract.

The second verse is where it breaks you. Because the second verse is specific. Not "I miss you" but "I miss the way you —" and the specificity is the knife.

I got through the first verse. The chat lit up.

@chennaigirl: 🥹🥹🥹 **@tamil_queen_88:**

His voice tho **@lonely_in_london:** Bro who hurt you **@deepa_dreams:** I'm not crying you're crying

I started the second verse. And my voice cracked.

Not a stylistic crack. Not the singer's ornamental break that signals emotion. A real crack. The kind where the vocal cords refuse to vibrate because the body has decided that the sound you're trying to make is too expensive and it can't afford it.

I stopped playing. The guitar hung from my hands. The chat kept moving but I wasn't reading it. I was looking at the viewer count. Forty-seven people. Forty-seven strangers watching a man sit in his living room at 9 PM on a Tuesday, unable to finish a song, unable to explain why, unable to say: the girl who used to sit in this chat and win every song game hasn't been here in seven months and I don't know if she's alive or dead and my wife is asleep upstairs and I am sitting on this couch singing Tamil love songs to strangers on the internet because strangers are the only people who will listen to me and even the strangers are leaving — thirty-one thousand followers and forty-seven showed up tonight, and that number is the most honest review of my life I've ever received.

"Sorry," I said. "Frog in my throat."

@raj_seattle: Take your time king

@lonely_in_london: We're here

I tried again. Got two lines into the verse. The word *nenjukkul* — “inside my heart” — and my hands stopped. Not because I chose to stop. Because my body stopped. The hands went still. The voice went silent. The breath caught somewhere between my lungs and my mouth and stayed there, trapped, the way everything was trapped — the love, the grief, the fifty-three messages she'd never read, the baby she'd had without telling me, the year of nothing that sat on my chest like a physical weight.

The chat was moving faster now. They could see it.

@chennaigirl: Bro are you okay???

@tamil_queen_88: Someone check on him

@deepa_dreams: Ari? ❤️

I stared at the phone. At the little camera light. At the forty-seven faces I couldn't see watching the one face they could. And I thought about all the nights Meera had sat in this chat and watched me perform and how she'd once said, “You're the only real thing on my phone,” and how I'd felt like a king when she said that, and how the king was now sitting on a couch in Seattle with a guitar he couldn't play, crying in front of forty-seven strangers because the girl who made him real had disappeared and taken reality with her.

“I gotta go,” I said. “Bad night. I’ll be back.”
I ended the Live.

* * *

TikTok Live Statistics *October 13, 2020*

Duration: 7 minutes, 34 seconds Peak Viewers: 51
Average Viewers: 44 New Followers: 0 Gifts Received:
3 roses (value: \$0.15) Comments: 62
Shortest Live in account history.

* * *

I sat on the couch for an hour after ending the Live.
The guitar across my lap. The phone face down on the
cushion beside me. Priya’s footsteps above me — she’d
gotten up to use the bathroom, flushed, gone back to
bed. The sound of a toilet flushing in a house where
two people lived and neither could hear the other
drowning.

I picked up the phone. Opened WhatsApp. Opened
her chat.

Fifty-three messages. All from me. All unread. All
delivered. Two blue ticks away from being seen, and
the two blue ticks never came.

I typed: *"I couldn't finish the song tonight. The one you used to request. You probably don't even know I went Live. You probably don't even think about the Lives anymore. But I went Live tonight and I couldn't finish the song and I think it's because you were the reason I could finish them in the first place. You were the engine. And the engine is gone and I'm just a man with a guitar on a couch in a house where nobody can hear me."*

My thumb hovered over send.

I deleted it. Character by character. Watching the words disappear in reverse. The way everything was disappearing in reverse. The song. The audience. The voice. Her.

I put the phone down. Picked up the guitar. Played the song again, from the beginning, in the dark living room, to no audience, to no camera, to no one.

I finished it this time.

Nobody heard.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 12: THE OTHER SIDE OF SILENCE

★ *Meera's POV*

* * *

WhatsApp — Contact Info Ari

Last seen: January 3, 2020, 11:14 PM PST Unread
messages from him: 5 Unanswered calls from him: 13

* * *

She could see all of it.

Every message. Every missed call. Every “please” and “are you okay” and “Meera?” with the question mark that got more desperate each time. She could see the timestamps. 6:02 AM his time, which meant he’d woken up and checked for her before checking anything else. 2:17 AM his time, which meant he couldn’t sleep. 12:41 AM his time, which meant he was on the couch in the dark, holding his phone like a man holding a rope over a cliff.

She saw it all. She read every word. And she didn't reply.

* * *

Here is what Ari doesn't know. What he'll probably never know, because she'll never be able to explain it in a way that doesn't sound like an excuse.

She didn't ghost him. She survived him.

* * *

It started in December.

The baby was three months old. Colicky. Screaming from 7 PM to midnight every night with the regularity of a factory alarm. Meera hadn't slept more than two consecutive hours since the birth. Her body was still leaking. Her nipples were cracked. Her stitches hadn't healed properly and nobody told her that was abnormal because women in her family didn't discuss what happened below the waist. You pushed. You bled. You recovered. You didn't complain.

Vikram was useless. Not maliciously. He simply existed in the category of Indian husband that considers childcare a woman's domain, the way plumbing is a plumber's domain. He'd hold the baby

when Meera handed her over, but he'd hold her like a parcel. At arm's length. Waiting for the actual parent to return and take the package back.

His mother was worse. Not because she didn't help — she helped constantly, aggressively, with the specific competence of a woman who'd raised three children and considered Meera's exhaustion a character flaw. "In my time, we didn't complain. We had two, three babies, no help, no fuss." Every offer of assistance came with an invoice of judgment.

And then there was Ari. On the phone. Every night. At midnight. Wanting to talk for four hours.

* * *

She loved him. That wasn't the problem. She loved him the way you love oxygen — desperately, automatically, without thinking about it. He was the only person in her life who asked how she was and actually waited for the answer. The only one who said "you're doing an amazing job" when her mother-in-law was saying "the baby shouldn't cry this much, you must be feeding her wrong." The only voice in her ear that wasn't demanding something.

But he was also demanding something. He just didn't know it.

Every call was a withdrawal. Not from love — from time. From sleep. From the tiny reserves of energy that a postpartum woman hoards like a squirrel hoards acorns. Every hour on the phone with Ari was an hour of sleep she didn't get, and every hour of sleep she didn't get was a morning where the baby's crying felt like a drill boring into her skull, and every drilling morning was a day where she was less patient with the baby, less careful around Vikram, less able to maintain the performance.

The performance was everything. Smile for the mother-in-law. Cook the sambar. Breastfeed on schedule. Don't flinch when Vikram reaches for you at night. Don't cry in front of anyone. Don't look at your phone when people can see. Don't let the mask slip.

And then at midnight: call Ari. Take off the mask. Be yourself. Feel loved. Feel seen. Feel human.

And then at 4 AM: hang up. Put the mask back on. Sleep for ninety minutes. Wake up to a screaming baby and a husband who wants breakfast and a mother-in-law who wants to know why the sambar is too thin.

She was running on fumes. And the fumes were Ari.

* * *

Google Search History — Meera's Phone

December 2019

“postpartum depression symptoms” “is it normal to want to run away from your baby” “can you love your child and hate your life” “sleep deprivation psychosis” “how many hours of sleep do you need to function”

Searches NOT cleared.

* * *

She stopped clearing the searches. That was the first sign. The woman who used to erase every trace of Ari from her phone within minutes had stopped caring whether Vikram found her search history. Let him find it. Let him see “can you love your child and hate your life.” Let him deal with that. Let anyone deal with anything that wasn't her problem for five minutes.

That scared her. The not caring. Because not caring was the step before not functioning, and not functioning was the step before something she wouldn't let herself name.

* * *

The decision happened on a Tuesday. Not dramatically. Not with tears or a journal entry or a

long internal monologue. It happened the way exhaustion makes decisions: suddenly, flatly, without ceremony.

She was breastfeeding the baby at 3 AM. The baby was latched but fussing, pulling at the nipple, unhappy with the flow or the position or the temperature or some baby grievance that couldn't be articulated. Meera's phone was on the bed beside her. Ari had called twice that evening. She hadn't picked up because the baby was screaming and by the time the screaming stopped, it was too late to call back. He'd texted: "Everything okay?" She'd replied: "Baby stuff. Call tomorrow."

Tomorrow. She'd said tomorrow.

And sitting there in the dark, with a baby attached to a breast that felt like raw hamburger, she thought: tomorrow I'll call him. And he'll want to talk for four hours. And I'll stay up until 4 AM. And then the baby will wake at 5:30. And I'll have slept ninety minutes. And I'll be worse tomorrow than I am today. And the day after that, worse again. And the day after that.

And one day I'll fall asleep while the baby is in the bath. Or I'll snap at Vikram and he'll snap back in the way that leaves bruises on the inside. Or I'll drive somewhere and forget where I'm going. Or I'll just

stop. Stop talking. Stop eating. Stop getting out of bed. Stop.

The math was simple. She didn't have enough hours in the day to be a mother, a wife, a secret lover, and a human being. Something had to go. And the only thing she could cut without someone in her physical life noticing was the man in her phone.

* * *

She didn't plan the silence. She just didn't call back. Tuesday became Wednesday. Wednesday became Friday. Friday became the next Tuesday. Each day she didn't call, the silence got heavier, and the heavier it got, the harder it was to break.

How do you call someone after four days of nothing and explain that you weren't dead, weren't angry, weren't ghosting — you were just trying not to drown? How do you say “I love you but I can't talk to you right now because talking to you is taking from a tank that's already empty?” How do you ask a starving man to understand that you can't feed him because you're starving too?

She couldn't. So she didn't. And the silence became its own wall, and the wall became permanent, and before she understood what had happened, a week

became a month, and a month became a season, and a season became a year.

* * *

WhatsApp — Voice Note to herself *February 2020, 3:33 AM IST Duration: 0:38 Saved to “Locked” folder*

“I’m losing both of them. Vikram because I don’t love him. Ari because I do. And I’m losing myself because there’s nothing left. The baby gets the milk. Vikram gets the body. Ari gets the silence. And Meera gets the ceiling.”

* * *

The ghosting wasn’t just exhaustion. It was an attempt. A desperate, doomed, last-ditch attempt to be the woman she was supposed to be. Wife. Mother. Daughter-in-law. A woman who didn’t have a man in a phone.

She moved his chat to archived. She turned off his notifications. She tried to stop thinking about him the way you try to stop a song from playing in your head. By force. By distraction. By filling the space with other things.

It didn't work. None of it worked. He was in her body. Not metaphorically. In her actual body. In the phantom sensation of his lips on her neck that came at random moments — while cooking, while driving, while breastfeeding — like a ghost of pleasure haunting a house of pain.

Two things that live in the same body: the memory of being loved and the memory of leaving.

She put the phone face-down. Closed her eyes.
The ceiling was waiting.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 13: MEERA'S YEAR ★

* * *

(The year she didn't pick up.)

The first week of January, she learns the geometry of one hand.

One hand holds the baby. The other does everything. Opens jars. Pours milk into a small pot and keeps one eye on it because milk remembers what you did to it last time. Holds the phone. Does not hold the phone. The phone is face down on the counter — the counter is yellow laminate that her mother chose in 1994, the counter where her mother used to roll chapatis while calling her stupid in three languages — and the phone is face down so she does not see who is calling.

She knows who is calling.

She has known for forty-two hours.

The baby is called Nila. Nila means moonlight. She is six months old and she has a fever that is not a fever; it is 99.8, which is a temperature, which is not fever, which is nothing, which is the reason Meera is awake at 4:11 a.m. for the fifth night in a row reading threads

from 2014 about whether a 99.8 in a breastfed infant means sepsis. It does not mean sepsis. It means she is warm. She is warm because her body is doing what bodies do. Meera's body has forgotten what bodies do. Her body has become a route — milk from there to there, arms from here to here — and sleep is a place she used to live.

Vikram is asleep in the other room because one of them has to work tomorrow and the job is his. That is the arithmetic they have agreed on. He is not a bad man. He is the kind of good man who can be asleep while she is awake and believe they are both doing the right thing. He is not wrong. She turns the phone over at 4:47 a.m. She sees the name. She turns the phone back.

By February she has a system.

The system is: if the phone rings and it is that name, she does not look at it for three minutes. She counts the three minutes against something — a pot of water coming to boil, a diaper, a verse from the Carnatic lullaby her grandmother used to hum that she now hums to Nila without remembering the words, so the hum is only the shape of remembering. Three minutes is long enough for the ringing to stop. Three minutes is long enough for her body to remember that it belongs to the baby now, to the house now, to this

smaller and cleaner life she chose and keeps choosing every morning when she does not pick up.

It is not that she does not want to pick up.

She wants to pick up so badly that she has developed a tic — her right hand, the phone hand, flutters involuntarily when a message lights the screen. Like a small animal deciding whether to cross a road. She watches her own hand. She thinks: that hand is not me. She thinks: the me that picks up is not the me that I am choosing to be.

She does not pick up.

She puts the phone in a drawer.

The drawer is under the yellow counter. The drawer holds coupons and batteries and the pacifier Nila rejected at four months. The drawer is a place that does not look like a decision. It looks like a drawer. She opens it. She puts the phone in. She closes it. She walks to the other side of the kitchen and pours herself water from the filter and drinks it slowly while her daughter breathes against her collarbone and does not know that her mother is, at this exact moment, keeping the world whole by the width of a drawer.

In March the pandemic arrives and it is almost a relief.

Not relief in the way she would say out loud. Relief in the way a cage is a relief for someone who could not

otherwise say no. The country closes. The city closes. Vikram is home now, in the third bedroom, on calls, being the kind of good man who apologizes for stepping on her silence when he refills his coffee. They pass each other in doorways. They have become extremely good at doorways.

Ari calls on the fourth day of lockdown. She lets it ring. He calls on the sixth day. She lets it ring. On the ninth day he texts: just tell me you're alive.

She reads the text.

She reads it again.

She puts the phone face-down on the bathroom counter and runs the shower at the hottest setting and sits on the tile floor of the shower with her back against the tile wall and lets the water hit her shoulder and thinks: I am alive. I am alive. I am alive. Then she thinks: he does not get to know that. Then she thinks: he already knows that. Then she cries, quietly, with the water on, for seven minutes, and then she gets up because Nila is crying in the other room and Nila does not know yet that there is a language in which her mother disappears.

She does not text back.

In April, her mother-in-law says it, across the dining table, not looking at her: You are a different person since the baby. A better person, I think.

She does not answer. She passes the dal.

Vikram says, later, in bed, not looking at her: She meant it as a compliment.

She does not answer. She turns toward the wall.

She thinks, looking at the wall: A better person is a smaller person. A better person is a person who does not pick up.

She thinks: If he knew — if either of them knew — that I am a better person only because I am choosing, every single day, not to become the worse person I know I am capable of being — would the compliment still be a compliment?

She thinks: No.

She sleeps.

In May she almost picks up.

It is a Tuesday. Nila has slept through the night for the first time in her life and Meera is not tired — she is the specific kind of not-tired that is its own vertigo, a body that does not know what to do with a morning. She makes coffee. Vikram is at his desk. The baby is in the swing. The phone rings. She looks at it. She picks it up. She holds it to her ear. She does not press the green button. She holds it to her ear as if it were already pressed and says, into the dead phone, quietly: I cannot. I cannot. I cannot.

The ringing stops.

She puts the phone down.

She drinks the coffee.

It is the closest she will come for the entire year.

In July she deletes his number. She does not delete the thread. She tells herself this is a distinction. She tells herself: the number is how he reaches me. The thread is how I remember. She tells herself these are different things. She is wrong and she knows she is wrong, which is what makes it a decision instead of an accident.

In August, Nila says amma. She cries at the sink.

In September, Vikram asks if she is okay. She says yes. He says, you would tell me, right? She says yes. He accepts this, the way he accepts most things, by not asking the second question. She is not sure whether this is love or a habit that has learned to look like love. She is not sure there is a difference. She is not sure she deserves to want a difference.

In October, Ari calls from an unknown number. She knows it is him the way a body knows a weather system before it arrives. She does not pick up. She saves the number to a contact she names DO NOT. She does this so that next time, if there is a next time, she will know without having to look.

In November, there is a next time.

She does not pick up.

In December, there is not a next time. The phone does not ring. She thinks: good. She thinks: finally. She sits at the yellow counter at 11:04 p.m. on a Tuesday in December and Vikram is asleep and Nila is asleep and the house is quiet in the way houses are quiet when a year is ending, and she looks at the phone on the counter and she thinks, very clearly, for the first time since January: I would like him to call me.

The phone does not ring.

She picks it up anyway. She turns it over. She looks at the screen. The screen is a photograph of Nila at four months old, laughing at something she cannot see in the frame — something off-camera that made her baby laugh and that she did not photograph because she was, instead, photographing her laughing at it.

She thinks: this is what I chose. This is what it looks like to have chosen it.

She puts the phone face-down.

She goes to bed.

She does not sleep.

In the morning, she does not pick up.

* * *

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PART FOUR: THE RETURN

2021 – 2022

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CHAPTER 14: THE CALL

* * *

iPhone Screen Time Report *Week of March 14, 2020*

Daily Average: 11h 47m Most Used: WhatsApp (4h 12m) · TikTok (3h 38m) · Safari (2h 01m) Pickups: 94/day First Pickup: 5:41 AM

* * *

iPhone Screen Time Report *Week of November 8, 2020*

Daily Average: 6h 03m Most Used: WhatsApp (47m) · YouTube (2h 14m) · Safari (1h 55m) Pickups: 31/day First Pickup: 7:20 AM

* * *

WhatsApp — Unsent Draft *Saved to Notes, June 2020*

“Meera, I don’t know if you’ll ever read this. I type things to you and delete them. That’s my hobby now.

Writing letters to a woman who left without saying goodbye and deleting them before the blue ticks can betray me. The baby must be walking by now. I hope she has your laugh.”

[Draft deleted]

* * *

Incoming Call — WhatsApp January 2021 Caller:
Meera Time: 11:47 PM PST

* * *

The phone rang and I forgot how to breathe.

Not because I didn’t recognize the name. Because I did. Because that name hadn’t appeared on my screen in over a year. Because I’d stared at that name in my contacts a thousand times, thumb hovering over the call button, never pressing it. And now it was calling ME.

I was on the couch. Of course I was. The couch had become my permanent address after midnight, the place where I existed between Priya’s silence and the rest of the world. The TV was on but I wasn’t watching. I was doing what I did every night: nothing. Breathing. Taking up space in a house that didn’t want me.

Then her name. Lighting up my phone like a flare
over open water.

Meera.

* * *

I answered on the second ring. Not the first, because I
needed one ring to convince myself this was real. Not
the third, because I'd waited twelve months and I
wasn't going to wait twelve more seconds.

"Hi," she said.

That word. That fucking word. The same "hi" from
the first video call. The same "hi" from the hotel room.
The same syllable that had started everything, and now
here it was again, quiet and nervous and real, pushing
through my phone speaker at 11:47 PM like a year of
silence was just a pause between sentences.

"Hi," I said.

Then: nothing. Five seconds of silence that held
twelve months of pain.

She broke first.

"I'm sorry," she whispered. "I'm so sorry."

* * *

She was crying before I could respond. Not the dramatic, gasping kind. The tired kind. The kind that comes from someone who's been holding it together for a year and just heard a voice that made the holding pointless.

"I know I don't deserve this call," she said. "I know I don't deserve you picking up. I know what I did. I know."

I should have been angry. A year of silence. A year of unanswered calls and unread messages and nights on the bathroom floor Googling whether heartbreak could kill you. I should have said: "You destroyed me. You left without a word. You took my maybe-daughter and vanished."

But the thing about being starving is: when food finally appears, you don't interrogate it. You eat.

"Are you okay?" I asked. Not "where have you been." Not "how could you." Not "do you know what you did to me." Just: are you okay.

Because after twelve months of not knowing, that was the only question that mattered.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *After the call . She typed what she couldn't say out loud*

Meera: I tried to make it work with him. For the baby. I thought if I cut you off, I could fix my marriage. I thought the distance would make me forget.

Ari: Did it?

Meera: Not for a single day. Not for a single hour.

Ari: Then why didn't you call sooner?

Meera: Because I was ashamed. Because I chose him over you and it didn't even work. The marriage is the same. He's the same. Nothing changed except I lost you.

Ari: You didn't lose me. I'm right here.

Meera: Why? After what I did, why are you still here?

Ari: Because I love you. That didn't stop when you stopped calling.

* * *

Relief.

That's what I felt. Not anger. Not resentment. Not the righteous fury of a man who'd been wronged. Relief. Pure, flooding, drowning relief. The kind that makes your whole body go slack, like you've been holding your breath underwater and someone just pulled you to the surface.

She was alive. She was here. She was sorry. She still loved me.

Everything else could be sorted later. The lies, the silence, the year of nothing, all of it could wait. Because right now, in this moment, the phone was ringing and it was HER and that was enough.

That should tell you everything about how deeply I loved this woman. A year of ghosting, and my first emotion was gratitude.

* * *

We talked until 4 AM. The way we used to. Like the year hadn't happened. Like we'd just taken a very long intermission and the second act was starting.

She told me everything. The baby was healthy. Growing. Walking now. Saying small words — “amma” mostly, and “no” with the conviction of a tiny Tamil dictator. “She says ‘no’ to everything,” Meera said. “Rice? No. Sleep? No. Bath? Absolutely not. She’s already more decisive than I’ve ever been.” I laughed. She laughed. And the laughing felt like medicine after twelve months of nothing. Her husband was the same: the switch still flipped behind closed doors, the perfect man in public, the monster in private. Her mother-in-

law suspected nothing. Her friends suspected nothing. The cage was intact.

But something had cracked. And the crack was me. Or rather, the absence of me.

“I realized something this year,” she said. “I can survive him. I’ve been surviving him for years. But I can’t survive not having someone who actually sees me. And you’re the only person who ever has.”

* * *

I had one condition.

Not anger. Not punishment. Not “you have to suffer first.” Just one clear, honest boundary.

“I want to come back,” I said. Then I stopped. Started again. “But I need — it has to be different this time. Actually different. Not ‘someday.’ An actual plan. Movement.” I ran out of words. “I don’t know how else to say it.”

She was quiet for a long time.

“I want that too,” she said.

“I need more than want. I need a decision.”

“Okay,” she said. “I’m deciding. You. I’m choosing you.”

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *January 2021, 4:12 AM PST*

Ari: Promise me one thing.

Meera: Anything.

Ari: Don't disappear again. If it's too hard, tell me. If you need space, tell me. If you're scared, tell me. But don't just vanish. I can survive anything except silence. You know that now.

Meera: I promise. No more silence. Never again.

Ari: Okay.

Meera: Okay.

Ari: Welcome back.

Meera: I never left. I just closed my eyes for a year.

* * *

"I just closed my eyes for a year."

That line almost killed me. Because it was beautiful and it was true and it was also a more generous reframing of ghosting than I'd ever heard. She hadn't left. She'd closed her eyes. Like the love was a dream she'd tried to wake up from, and when she opened her eyes, it was still there. Still real. Still breathing.

I wanted to believe that. So I did.

* * *

The calls resumed. Every day. The rhythm came back like muscle memory: her afternoon, my midnight, the overlap where we existed in our own time zone. The baby on her lap sometimes, babbling in the background. Me on the couch, earbuds in, Priya asleep or awake or somewhere in between.

It was like someone had pressed play after a year-long pause. The same movie. The same characters. The same love.

But something was different this time. Not between us. Between me and myself.

The man who'd answered the phone wasn't the same man who'd sent those thirteen unanswered calls. That man had been desperate. Hungry. Willing to beg for scraps of attention because scraps were all he'd ever known.

This man, the one who said "only if you're committing," he'd grown something in that year of silence. Not toughness. Not walls. Something subtler. The beginning of knowing his own worth.

I didn't recognize it then. It was too small, too new. Like a seed that doesn't know it's a seed. But it was there. And it would grow.

Just not fast enough to prevent what came next.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 15: THE PATTERN

* * *

Video Call Log — Summary *January – June 2021*

Total calls: 147 Total duration: 612 hours, 18
minutes Average call length: 4 hours, 10 minutes
Longest call: 7 hours, 33 minutes (Valentine's Day)

* * *

Six hundred and twelve hours. In six months. That's twenty-five and a half days of continuous talking. More hours than most couples spend in conversation in a year. More intimacy than my marriage had produced in a decade.

We were back. Completely. The calls. The laughter. The intimacy. The plans whispered at 3 AM about a future that neither of us had the courage to build. We were two addicts who'd been sober for a year and had just relapsed hard, and the high was exactly as good as we remembered.

Better, even. Because now we knew what the withdrawal felt like.

* * *

The first few months were honeymoon. Pure reunion energy. She was attentive. Present. Answering every call on the first ring. Texting good morning before I woke up and good night after I fell asleep. Sending photos of the baby , my maybe-baby, the girl with my forehead. Crawling, standing, laughing, existing in a world I could only access through a screen.

She was performing commitment. And I was watching the performance, wanting so badly to believe it was real that I mistook the wanting for believing.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *February 2021*

Ari: Have you talked to him about separation?

Meera: Not yet. The timing isn't right.

Ari: When will the timing be right?

Meera: Soon. I promise. I just need to figure out the logistics. The baby, the house, my mother-in-law...

Ari: I understand. But "soon" needs a date. Otherwise it's just a word.

Meera: Give me until summer. Please.

Ari: Okay. Summer.

* * *

Summer came.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *July 2021*

Ari: It's summer.

Meera: I know. I'm working on it.

Ari: Working on it how?

Meera: I talked to my sister. She's supportive. But I need to talk to my parents first.

Ari: When?

Meera: Soon.

* * *

"Soon" has no deadline. "Soon" is "I will, but not yet" in a smaller word.

I kept buying it. Because the alternative, accepting that she might never leave, was a truth I wasn't ready to swallow.

* * *

The pattern set itself like concrete.

Monday through Friday: calls at night. Her afternoon, my midnight. The same window. The same rhythm. She'd tell me about her day. I'd tell her about mine. We'd laugh. We'd argue about something small : a movie, a song, whose turn it was to say "I love you" first. Then it would turn intimate. Voices dropping. Screens getting darker. Bodies responding to each other across thirteen time zones like they'd been trained to. Orgasms. Whispered goodnights. Sleep.

Saturday and Sunday: harder. Her husband was home. Less freedom. Shorter calls. More texting. She'd sneak to the bathroom to voice-note me while he watched cricket in the living room. I'd check my phone every thirty seconds like a teenager, waiting for the green notification that meant she was alive and still mine.

Underneath all of it, the question I asked every week: "When?"

Her answer, every week, in different words but the same meaning: "Not yet."

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *September 2021*

Ari: I need to ask you something and I need you to be honest.

Meera: Okay.

Ari: Are you still sleeping with him?

Meera: He forces me. You know that.

Ari: I know. But I'm asking: is it ONLY when he forces you?

Meera: What are you saying?

Ari: I'm saying: is there ever a time when it's not forced? When it's... I don't know. When you don't resist?

Meera: How can you ask me that?

Ari: Because I need to know. If we're committed, I need to know what's happening in that house.

Meera: He forces me. That's all. I don't want him. I never want him. You know who I want.

Ari: Okay. I'm sorry. I believe you.

* * *

I believed her. I did. Ninety percent of me believed her completely. But the other ten percent, the part that remembered the pregnancy, the timing, the "it could be yours" that turned out to be a lie, sat in the back of my mind like a pilot light. Always on. Always warming the gas.

Suspicion doesn't need certainty. Ten percent is enough. You don't need to fully doubt someone to

poison the relationship. You just need a whisper. A flicker. The smallest “what if” that plays on a loop at 3 AM when you’re alone and she’s in a house with a man who sleeps next to her and you don’t.

* * *

I asked her not to have sex with her husband.

Typed it out in a message because I couldn’t say it out loud. Because out loud, the words would have sounded like what they were: a desperate man trying to control a situation he had no control over, from the other side of the planet, through a five-inch screen.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *October 2021*

Ari: I need to ask you something difficult.

Meera: Ask.

Ari: I need you to stop having sex with him. Even when he forces you. I know that sounds impossible. But if we’re committed, I can’t handle knowing that another man is inside you. Even against your will. I know that’s selfish. I know that’s maybe even unfair. But I’m being honest.

Meera: ...

Meera: You know I can't always stop him.

Ari: I know. But can you try? Can you resist more?
Can you make it harder for him?

Meera: I already do. Every time. He doesn't care.

Ari: Then we need to get you out of that house.
This can't keep going.

Meera: I know. I'm working on it.

Ari: When?

Meera: Soon.

* * *

Soon.

The word landed like a hammer on glass. The same word. The same promise. The same elastic timeline that stretched to infinity while my patience wore thinner.

I swallowed it. Again. Because what was the alternative? She was being raped and I was asking her to stop it, as if stopping rape was a scheduling decision. As if she could pencil "resist harder" into her calendar between "feed the baby" and "call Ari at midnight."

I knew it was unreasonable. I knew it was born from jealousy masquerading as concern. But I also knew that every night I didn't know what was

happening in that bedroom, a part of me died. Not the dramatic kind of dying. The erosion kind. The kind where you lose yourself so slowly you don't notice until you look in the mirror and don't recognize the face.

* * *

Ari's Journal — iPhone Notes App November 2021

"I love her. I love her. I love her."

"And I'm starting to not trust her. And those two things are living inside me at the same time, in the same body, using the same heart, and the contradiction is eating me alive."

* * *

The months blurred. January became March became June became September. The calls continued. The intimacy continued. The "when?" continued. The "soon" continued.

She was mine every night and his every morning. I lived for the overlap and died in the gap.

I was hers. Completely, desperately, foolishly. In a way that was starting to cost me more than I could afford.

But I couldn't stop. Because stopping meant going back to the house. The counter. The keys. The wife facing the wall.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *December 2021, 11:59 PM PST*

Meera: Happy New Year, my love. ❤️ This is our year.

Ari: You said that last year.

Meera: This time I mean it.

Ari: You said that too.

Meera: ...

Meera: I deserve that.

Ari: No. You don't. I'm sorry. Happy New Year. I love you.

Meera: I love you too. I promise. This year.

* * *

2022 would be different. She promised. And I believed her. Because the only thing more powerful than a pattern is the hope that this time, the pattern will break.

It didn't.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER 16: THE SECOND CROSSING

* * *

Flight Confirmation — Delta / Air India Booked:
March 2022

Passenger: Arivazhagan Velmurugan Route: SEA
→ DEL → [redacted] Departure: April 8, 2022 Return:
April 15, 2022 Class: Economy Total: \$1,487.00

* * *

Seven days this time. Not three. I wasn't going to make the same mistake twice. I'd left when we'd barely started. Not this time. This time I bought a full week. Seven days. One hundred and sixty-eight hours. Enough time to do more than just prove the love was real. Enough time to live inside it.

The lie to Priya was easier now. Practice makes perfect, and I'd had years of practice. "Work trip to Bangalore. Visiting the India engineering team." She nodded. Same nod. Same closed door.

I was getting better at lying. That should have been a warning sign. When deception stops costing you, it means something inside you has already broken.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *April 7, 2022 — night before departure*

Meera: I can't sleep.

Ari: Me neither.

Meera: Last time you came for three days and changed my life. What's going to happen in seven?

Ari: I guess we'll find out.

Meera: I'm nervous.

Ari: About what?

Meera: That it's been so long since we've touched. What if it's different?

Ari: It won't be different.

Meera: How do you know?

Ari: Because the last time I saw you, you melted in my arms. And I haven't forgotten how to hold you. Bodies remember, even when the mind worries.

Meera: 🥲 Get on the plane already.

* * *

Three years since the last time I'd been in the same room as her. Three years of screens and voices and "I will, but not yet." Three years of the pattern. And now I was going back. She hadn't committed. Nothing had changed. But the wanting had become its own gravity, and I was tired of resisting it.

* * *

Hotel — Day One

Same city. Different hotel. Better room. I'd upgraded this time because something in me wanted to signal, to her, to myself, to the universe, that this wasn't the same desperate trip as last time. Last time I came to save her. This time I came to love her. The distinction mattered.

She walked in and the three years collapsed.

She was different. Not physically. She was the same dark hair, same warm eyes, same smile that started slow. But there was something underneath. A weariness from three years of living a double life. From mothering a toddler in a violent household. From promising a man across the ocean that she'd leave and knowing, somewhere deep, that she might not.

I held her. She held me. We stood in the middle of the room for five minutes without speaking. Just

breathing. Just existing in the same physical space after thirty-six months of pixels and speakers.

“You’re real,” she said. Same words as last time.

“Still real,” I said.

* * *

The first two days were like coming home to a house you’d been dreaming about. Every room familiar. Every surface known. But also different, because you’d been away long enough to see it with fresh eyes.

We made love slowly. Relearning each other. Her body had changed. Motherhood had softened her in places, strengthened her in others. My body had changed too. I was leaner, more restless, carrying the tension of a man who’d been living on phone calls and insomnia for three years.

But the connection was the same. Deeper, even. Because now there was history. Not just the love history. The pain history. The ghosting. The return. The fights. The “soon.” All of it had carved channels in us, and the intimacy flowed through those channels like water through a canyon: faster, deeper, more powerful than before.

She cried every time we made love. Not from sadness. From the accumulated weight of everything

she felt and couldn't express in any other way. Tears were her language when words weren't big enough.

* * *

Day Three — The Shift

Something changed on day three. A gear clicked into place. The nervousness was gone. The careful tenderness of the first two days gave way to something rawer. More honest. More urgent.

She wanted more.

Not more of me . She had all of me. More of herself. She wanted to find the parts of her body that she'd never explored. The places her husband had made into battlegrounds. She wanted to reclaim them. With me. Here. In this room where she was safe.

"I want you to take your time," she said. "I want you to touch me everywhere. I want to know what my body can do when it's not being forced."

So I took my time.

* * *

I learned her body that week the way a cartographer learns a coastline — slowly, carefully, honoring every

curve and inlet and secret cove that most people sail past without noticing.

I found the spot on her inner thigh that made her gasp. The ridge of her collarbone that made her arch when I kissed it. The small of her back where, if I pressed with just the right amount of warmth, her entire body would soften like heated glass.

She discovered things too. Things about herself. Things no one had ever helped her find because no one had ever looked.

On day four, I was inside her. Slow. Deep. The way we'd learned to move together, not thrusting so much as breathing in rhythm, letting the intimacy build like a wave that doesn't break but keeps rising.

I reached between us. Found her with my fingers. How I knew she needed it. Circles, pressure, patience. My body and my hand working together. Two kinds of attention at the same time.

Her breathing changed. Not the familiar quickening. Something different. Deeper. More primal. Her eyes went wide.

"Something's happening," she whispered. "I don't know what — something's—"

"Let it happen," I said. "Don't fight it. I'm here."

She gripped the sheets. Her back arched off the bed. Her legs shook . Not trembled, SHOOK , like an

earthquake was starting in her spine and radiating outward.

Then: release.

She squirted. For the first time in her life.

* * *

It was everywhere. The sheets. My hands. Her thighs. A flood of surrender that her body had been holding for years, decades. That no one had ever unlocked because no one had ever been patient enough, present enough, safe enough to reach that deep.

She was mortified.

“Oh God — oh God, I’m sorry . I don’t know what — I’m so—”

She was scrambling for sheets. Trying to cover herself. Trying to hide the evidence of her own pleasure like it was something shameful. Because that’s what she’d been taught. That her body was a liability. That what it did was embarrassing. That pleasure was something to endure, not to celebrate.

I caught her hands. Gently. Held them.

“Hey. Look at me.”

She looked. Eyes wet. Cheeks flushed. Terrified.

“That was the best thing I’ve ever seen,” I said.

“But the sheets—”

“Fuck the sheets.”

She laughed. A single, startled laugh that broke through the embarrassment like sunlight through a crack. Then she was crying and laughing at the same time. The specific combination that means a human is feeling too much and the body can't decide which valve to open.

“It's okay,” I said. “It's more than okay. That was YOUR body doing what it was always designed to do. That wasn't me. That was you.”

She buried her face in my chest. Shaking.
Laughing. Crying.

“How?” she whispered. “How did you do that?”

“I didn't. You did. I just didn't leave.”

* * *

She squirted three more times that week. Each time less surprised. Each time less embarrassed. By the sixth day, she was laughing when it happened. Delighted, almost gleeful, like a child discovering that she could fly.

“You broke my body,” she said, grinning.

“I didn't—” I started. “I don't know. You did it.”

“Same thing,” she said.

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CHAPTER 17: THE DISCOVERY

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Hotel Kitchenette — Day 3 *April 2022*

Two eggs. One pan. No oil because we'd forgotten to buy oil and the corner shop was closed and it was 7 AM and neither of us wanted to put on clothes.

"Butter?" she said, holding up a packet from the minibar that cost more than the eggs.

"Minibar butter on eggs is a crime against economics."

"You fly business class to India and you're worried about butter?"

"I fly economy. I said business to impress you."

"You failed." She cracked the eggs. Both yolks broke. "See? The universe agrees."

We stood in a kitchenette the size of a closet in a hotel that charged by the week because I'd booked seven days this time. Seven. Not three. Not a weekend. A week. Because three days in 2019 had taught me that you can't build anything real in seventy-two hours. You can ignite. You can burn. But you can't settle. And I wanted to know what settling felt like with her.

She scrambled the eggs with minibar butter and hotel salt and I made chai with tea bags that tasted like cardboard and we sat on the bed and ate with our fingers because neither of us had remembered to pack forks and the hotel's room service didn't start until 8.

"This is terrible," she said.

"The eggs or the chai?"

"Both. All of it." She was grinning. "This is the worst breakfast I've ever had."

"Worse than your mother-in-law's upma?"

"Nothing is worse than Amma's upma. But this is close."

We laughed. Morning laughing. The lazy, stupid kind that happens before coffee, before the world starts, before you remember that this isn't your life. This is a parenthesis. A week-long interruption of the sentence you're both actually living.

But for seven days, the parenthesis was the whole story.

* * *

Day 3 was when I discovered something about Meera that the phone had hidden for four years.

She was mean.

Not cruel. Mean in the way Tamil women are mean when they're comfortable. The aunty gene. The gene that lies dormant until a woman trusts you enough to stop being polite, and then suddenly every sentence has teeth.

"You snore," she said on Day 2.

"I don't snore."

"You snore like an auto-rickshaw with a broken muffler. I recorded it." She held up her phone. She'd actually recorded it. Three minutes of me, mouth open, producing sounds that no human should make.

"Delete that."

"Never. This is insurance."

"Against what?"

"Against you ever claiming you're smooth."

The phone had given me the curated Meera. The beautiful one. The vulnerable one. The one who cried during video calls and said "I miss you" in a voice that made my chest ache. That Meera was real. But she was incomplete. She was Meera without morning breath. Meera without blanket-hogging so aggressive I'd wake up at 3 AM with nothing but a bedsheet and a draft. Meera without the fifteen-minute bathroom routine that involved products I couldn't name and a hairdryer she used like a weapon.

The real Meera left wet towels on the bed. The real Meera talked during movies. Not whispered. Talked. Full volume. “Why is he going in there? He’s going to die. Don’t go in there. He went in there. Idiot.”

The real Meera argued about the AC temperature with the passion of a labor negotiator. She wanted 24. I wanted 20. We settled on 22 after a debate that lasted longer than most UN resolutions.

“Twenty-two is neither warm nor cool,” she said. “It’s nothing. You’ve condemned us to nothing.”

“Twenty-two is compromise.”

“Compromise is what you call defeat when you don’t want to admit you lost.”

I loved her more after that fight than after any midnight phone call. Because the fight was real. The fight was proximity. The fight was two people sharing a thermostat and a bathroom and a bed for seven days and discovering that love doesn’t dissolve friction — it just makes friction survivable.

* * *

Day 4 — The Walk

We left the hotel. For the first time.

Three years of loving this woman and I’d never walked next to her in daylight. Never been beside her

in a crowd. Never seen her interact with the world while standing close enough to touch.

She wanted to show me a temple. Not a tourist temple. A neighborhood one. Small. Tucked between a tailor shop and a phone repair stall. The kind of temple you'd miss if you weren't looking, which was the point. "The best temples are the ones nobody photographs," she said.

We walked through streets that smelled like jasmine garlands and diesel and frying batter. She walked fast. That surprised me. On the phone she was languid, unhurried, a woman who stretched words like taffy. In person she moved like she was late for something. Short legs, quick steps, weaving through the crowd with the efficiency of someone who'd spent her whole life navigating sidewalks that weren't designed for pedestrians.

I couldn't keep up. My American legs, trained for parking lots and wide suburban sidewalks, stumbled on the broken pavement.

"Faster," she said.

"I'm twice your height."

"And half my speed. Move."

She grabbed my hand. In public. In daylight. In a country where a married woman holding a man's hand who isn't her husband could unravel her entire life.

I looked at her. She wasn't thinking about any of that. She was just holding my hand because she wanted to and the crowd was thick and she didn't want to lose me. The simplicity of it. The ordinary danger. A woman grabbing a man's hand on a crowded street, not as a statement, not as defiance, just because his legs were too slow and she wanted him next to her.

I held on.

* * *

We reached the temple. She was right. It was small. A single room with a stone floor and a brass bell and a deity I recognized but couldn't name because my temple education had gaps the size of continents.

She didn't pray. She stood with her hands at her sides and looked at the shrine for a long time. The incense smoke curled around her face. The light from a single oil lamp caught the edge of her jaw.

"I used to come here as a kid," she said. "Before Vikram. Before everything. My grandmother would bring me. She'd pray for an hour and I'd sit on the steps and watch the flowers."

"What flowers?"

"Jasmine. They'd string them fresh every morning. The smell would stay in my hair all day. My mother

would know I'd been to the temple because I'd smell like jasmine."

She still smelled like jasmine. I didn't say that. Some things are too obvious to say and too important to leave unsaid. I said nothing. She knew.

We stood in the temple for ten minutes. She didn't pray. I didn't pray. We just stood in a room that smelled like her childhood and let the silence be enough.

* * *

Day 5 — The Fight

The real one.

Not the AC fight. Not the snoring fight. A real fight about nothing, which is the only kind that matters.

It started with lunch. She wanted to eat at a restaurant she remembered from college. I wanted to order in because I was tired and the heat was medieval and the idea of putting on real pants felt like an act of violence.

"You didn't fly eight thousand miles to eat hotel food," she said.

"I flew eight thousand miles to be with you. The food is negotiable."

“The food is NOT negotiable. This restaurant has the best kothu parotta in the city. You’re going.”

“I’m not going.”

“Then I’m going alone.”

“Fine.”

“Fine.”

We stared at each other. Two adults in a hotel room, both furious about kothu parotta. The stupidest fight in the history of international love affairs.

She put on her shoes. I put on my shoes. We walked to the restaurant without speaking. The silence lasted fourteen minutes. I know because I counted the steps and divided by my average stride and then realized I was doing math to avoid dealing with my feelings, which is the most me thing I’ve ever done.

The kothu parotta was exceptional. The best I’d ever had. The sound of the metal spatulas chopping the parotta on the griddle, the smell of onion and egg and masala, the first bite that made me close my eyes because flavor this aggressive demands respect.

“Good?” she said.

“Incredible.”

“I know.”

She didn’t say “I told you so.” Tamil women don’t need to. They just sit across from you and eat with the

quiet satisfaction of a person who was right and has decided to be gracious about it.

That fight — the kothu parotta fight — is my favorite memory from the whole trip. Not the sex. Not the temple. Not the hand-holding on the crowded street. The fight. Because the fight was normal. The fight was what couples do. The fight was evidence that we weren't just two people escaping into each other. We were two people who could annoy each other, disagree, go silent, and then sit across a table eating kothu parotta without anyone apologizing because the fight was already over and the food was too good to ruin with words.

That's what the phone never gave us. The ordinary. The stupid. The fights about nothing that teach you more about a person than any midnight confession ever could.

* * *

Day 5 — Later

After the kothu parotta. After the making up that happened wordlessly in the auto-rickshaw back, her head on my shoulder, my hand on her knee. After the hotel room door closed.

She stood by the window. Afternoon light. The curtains were thin and the sun came through in stripes that painted her body in gold and shadow.

“I want to show you something,” she said.

She undressed slowly. Not like the first time in 2019, which was urgent, desperate, two people ripping at each other because the clock was already counting down. This was different. This was a woman taking her clothes off in daylight, in a room where she’d been living for five days, with a man she’d fought with about parotta two hours ago.

No urgency. No performance. Just: here. This is my body. In daylight. With the stretch marks from the baby and the scar from the C-section and the place on my hip where the skin dimples when I stand a certain way. Here. All of it. Look.

I looked.

“You’re staring,” she said.

“You told me to look.”

“I told you to look, not stare. There’s a difference.”

“What’s the difference?”

“Looking is polite. Staring is what you’re doing.”

“I’ll stare.”

She laughed. The nervous kind. The kind that happens when a woman shows a man her body in daylight and he doesn’t look away.

What happened next isn't for this chapter. Some things exist between two bodies and a thin-curtained window and they don't need an audience. I'll tell you this: it lasted three hours. I'll tell you that somewhere in the second hour she made a sound I'd never heard before, not on the phone, not in the dark, a sound that only exists in afternoon light when a body has been touched slowly enough and long enough that it forgets to be self-conscious.

I'll tell you that after, she lay on her stomach with her face in the pillow and said "I can't feel my legs" and I said "good" and she threw the pillow at me and missed and we both laughed until laughing turned into kissing and kissing turned into the third hour.

And I'll tell you that at 6 PM, when the light had changed from gold to amber, she sat up in bed with the sheet around her waist and said:

"This is what I wanted the marriage to be."

Not to wound me. Not to compare. Just to say, out loud, what the last five days had proven: that she was capable of this. Of wanting. Of laughing during sex. Of fighting about parotta and making up without words. Of being a woman in a room with a man and feeling like she was supposed to be there.

She'd just never been in the right room.

* * *

Room Service Receipt *Day 5, 8:47 PM*

2x Biryani (Chicken) 1x Naan 1x Raita 2x Chai 1x
Gulab Jamun (4 pieces)

Total: ₹1,420 Tip: ₹200

Note scrawled on receipt in Meera's handwriting:
"He ordered too much again 😬"

* * *

Day Seven

The last day. Again. The ticking clock. The departure board. The return to the real world.

But this time was different. This time I'd been there for a week. This time we'd had more than borrowed hours. Borrowed days. We'd cooked together in the hotel kitchenette. We'd watched a movie in bed. We'd fought over the remote. We'd done the ordinary, boring, miraculous things that couples do when they live together.

For seven days, we weren't a love affair. We were a relationship. And the taste of it was so sweet that leaving felt like swallowing glass.

* * *

WhatsApp Messages *April 15, 2022 — Airport*

Meera: When are you coming back?

Ari: I don't know.

Meera: That's what you said last time.

Ari: Last time I came back.

Meera: Promise?

Ari: I promise. But Meera — next time, I don't want to come to a hotel. I want to come to YOUR home. To OUR home. Not his.

Meera: ...

Meera: I'm working on it.

Ari: I know. I love you.

Meera: I love you. Seven days wasn't enough.

Ari: Seven lifetimes wouldn't be enough. But who's counting.

* * *

I boarded the plane carrying the smell of her on my clothes and the memory of her body discovering itself in my hands. Eight thousand miles ahead of me, a dead marriage waited. Behind me, a woman I loved was walking back into a house with a man who didn't deserve to share her air.

Between us: the pattern. Resuming. The calls. The "when?" The "soon."

But something had shifted. Not in the pattern. In me.

For the first time, I wasn't just hoping the pattern would break. I was beginning to wonder what would happen if it didn't. What I would do. Who I would become.

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